Destiny and Other Lies

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35857924.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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catradora - Relationship, Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Glimbow - Relationship, Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Fluff and Angst, Fluff, Alternate Universe - Soulmates, magicatra, Destiny, Kisses, Cuddles, Pining, Longing

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SPOP Flex Secret Solstice

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by EmiliaGryphon

Summary

When Catra is finally given a mission to lead with her squad, things go horribly wrong. She lost her skiff and her data pad, but she found a magical sword....it's probably not related to that birthmark" on her wrist...that is starting to glow.

A magicatra/soulmates AU where Adora and Catra missed each other and Catra is Shera

Warnings for swearing, mentions of child abuse

Please pardon any soulmate related errors, this is the first time I've written this type of fic!

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

A Folly in the Woods

“Catra! Catra!”

Something shoved her roughly, the cadet spasmed, leaping from her bunk, tail stick-straight, claws out.

“Easy Catra!” Lonnie scolded, the annoyingly acrobatic squad mate had hoisted herself up to the top bunk, and leaned backward holding on with nothing but her legs, her arms up defensive, ready to block herself from the magicat's claws. It wouldn’t be the first time Catra had clawed her smartly for waking her up.

She should know better.

“What time is it?” Catra asked, rubbing her eyes, her tail now relaxed as she came more awake by degrees. It no longer stuck straight out in shock but lazily swished from side to side over the edge of the bunk.

“Time for you to get moving!” Lonnie had always been a morning person. Just another quality Catra found irritating. Always the first one awake, always the first one out of the barracks to the mess hall.

Goody two-shoes is going to be Force Captain as soon as she turns eighteen.

Catra was sure of it. The hair on the back of her neck stood up at the mere thought. She growled at Lonnie, baring her pointed fangs.

“Octavia wants to see you, orders from the top.”

Hordak.

Shadow Weaver.

She vaulted down from the bunk, a fire of ambitious energy quickly taking over. Catra landed expertly on four feet, straightening up as fast as she could. She learned the hard way Shadow Weaver didn't like it when she ran on all fours. It was too animalistic. Too beastly.

No. Not thinking about that old hag today. If Hordak wants something from me that's all that matters.

She dressed, racing for her headpiece that lay among her clothes and toiletries. The only possession of her own. The only thing that was truly hers. She squinted, reaching up to her thin blanket and tugging it down, giving the red metal a good rub, not perfect, but it would have to do. She placed it on her head carefully, sparring a small smile in the shared mirror at the end of the bunk rows.

That's it Catra, you can do this. You can do this. You're just as capable as Lonnie, definitely more capable than Kyle. Shadow Weaver doesn't matter, Hordak will see. If I can carry out these orders, he'll finally see.

I'll be something.

She touched the little birth-mark on the inside of her left wrist, a small perfectly circular patch of skin only a shade or two darker than the rest of her body. No matter her other scars, no amount of Shadow Weaver's magic had ever altered or scarred it.

I'll show him that I can be something more than Shadow Weaver's punching bag.

She stole a breath, waiting for her chest to cease its nervous pounding, ran a hand through her tawny unruly hair, and stepped out into the corridor.

"Cadet! There you are!"

Octavia's growling voice cut Catra from her thoughts. She stood straight, nodding, trying her best to mask any hatred towards the

Senior Force Captain. Still, the eye patch gave Catra cause to grin inwardly.

That was a day to remember.

"Yes, Force Captain Octavia?" Catra put on her best "how-may-I-please-you?" tone. The squid-like woman narrowed her remaining yellow eye. Serrated shark teeth peeking out from her thin grimace. Catra eyed her back, until she finally looked down at her control pad.

"Hordak has a job for you. You're to take your squadron into the Whispering Woods to do a sweep. Report any sign of princess activity. But it is only an intelligence sweep. No bots, no casualties. Understood?"

The Whispering Woods? On my own with a squadron? Me? Leading the sweep? Intelligence?!

Catra's tail betrayed her excitement, eagerly raising and switching and back fourth.

"When do I go?! I...I mean, yes Force Captain Octavia," Catra forced, bowing slightly.

"You leave in T-2 hours. Prepare your squad, and take this," Octavia fished another data bad from her belt, throwing it to Catra who expertly caught it in one hand. "For any live footage and thermal radiation or magic detection. Hordak expects a full report by tomorrow this time."

Catra nodded, trying and failing to quell her excitement. She flicked the data pad on and turned to go.

"Oh and Catra?"

She knew that tone. The magicat stopped in her tracks but kept her back to the Force Captain.

"I've been told by Shadow Weaver that any gap in intelligence, any slight mishap, any late return for whatever reason, any incomplete report will result in, how did she say it? "Skinning the cat?"

Her claws flashed out, ears flattening to her skull.

Lightning. Blinding, bone-breaking magic. Sharp burning fur. Scalding Skin.

Run. Go. Get away. Hide!

Her chest heaved, ready to hold her breath, ready to bolt. Her heterochromatic eyes gleaned this way and that, frantically searching the shadows of the green metallic corridor.

Breathe. Keep calm! Don't let her get a rise out of you!

Catra masked her rage, her fear, instantly, ears flicking forward again. She curled her fingers into her palm, retracting her claws.

"That only bat can say whatever she wants. I'll find whatever princess activity is out there and hand *Hordak,* the most comprehensive report he's ever seen. Thank you Octavia, I can take it from here."

Satisfied, Catra clipped the data pad to her belt and took-off down the halls of the Fright Zone towards the practice fields.

"...and Hordak wants you to lead this mission?" Lonnie leaned forward, hands on her hips, scrutinizing Catra bitterly.

"Yup! Octavia told me he said he'd trust no one else."

Rogelio leveled her with an unbelieving eye but Catra ignored him.

"Sure he did," Lonnie drawled, skeptical.

"Doesn't matter what you think Lonnie. Those were the orders so that's what we're going to do. A sweep, got it?"

Kyle nodded beside Rogelio, eyes wide with preemptive anxiety.

"Fine," Lonnie replied coolly, a stun baton still clutched in her left hand. "But you better put in a good word for us in your report. This is a team effort."

"Then I suggest you get going and prep a skiff," Catra matched her hostility with a hiss. As usual, Lonnie met her vitriol with contempt, fist clenched around the baton but she huffed after a second, motioning for Rogelio and Kyle to follow. Catra watched them go, walking a little too care-free across the practice fields towards the transport bay.

You can do this Catra. Just keep your guard up, document everything. Don't slip up.

Shadow Weaver's threat, even through Octavia's terse words, still rang in her sensitive ears. Always a punishment looming, always the sorceress watching her every move. Always something to prove and nothing to lose. But this time it would be different. This time she'd succeed. This time she would return triumphant with the best, most detailed intelligence sweep even a Senior Force Captain couldn't log.

I can do this. It'll be great, Even with Lonnie. She can't spoil this for me I won't let her. Even if I have to….

"Hey there, Wild Cat!"

Catra leapt straight upward, levitating momentarily before realizing who it was with a flare of anger.

"Scorpia! I told you not to sneak up on me like that!"

“Ohhhh, yeah, right, sorry Wild Cat! I just...you being a cat and all, I thought you could smell me or hear me coming you know, suuuper stealthy like you are.” The large scorpion woman beamed. Catra shoved down any malice towards her.

“Scorpia, I’m kinda busy right now,” she reached for her data pad and tried experimentally fiddling with it trying to get Scorpio to take the hint.

“That’s right! Your big mission! The one to the Whispering Woods! You’re going to do so great Wild Cat! Just...just be careful out there okay?!”

“Yeah, yeah, I will. Now I have to go get ready okay? I’ll see you tomorrow.”

Scorpia grinned so wide Catra wondered how her jaw remained in-tact. Little time to wonder though, as two very large, very constricting claws wrapped around her torso and lifted her off the ground once more.

“Just please watch yourself okay?! Who knows what could be lurking in the woods! There’s mean beasties and abandoned First-Ones ruins, and worse of all….” she paused for dramatic effect, “PRINCESSES! Oh my sweet Wild Cat, just be careful!”

“Will you let me go?” Catra hissed at the indignity, her claws not as powerful against Socorpia’s solid hard exoskeleton. The Force Captain let her down, her eyes gleaming with misplaced admiration. Catra huffed awkwardly, never sure how to handle the woman’s enthusiasm and relentless energy, never mind the persistent desire to be friends.

Was Scorpia a friend? She helped me with my wounds that one time after Shadow Weaver...what am I talking about? Question for another time!

“Look, I really have to leave. I’ll tell you everything tomorrow.”

“You got it Wild Cat! Take care!”

Catra managed a haphazard wave over her shoulder before turning back to her data pad.

"This is Force Captain Catra Log 01," she giggled to herself, "just kidding. Cadet Catra. Cadet Catra's Log 01."

Shit no, this isn't time for jokes! Be serious!

Scorpia laughs at my jokes...I mean she'll laugh at anything but…

Catra shrugged, putting on her serious face once more just as Rogelio's bright green scales came into view. She inspected the skiff, plenty of fuel, supplies, four stun battens, some trackers, some tiny cameras, other gadgets and a small explosive, just in case of an emergency.

"Looks good," Catra managed, finished inspection. Lonnie gave a curt nod, jumping on board and helping Kyle up.

"You ready to go?" The Force Captain overseeing the transport bay did a final check. Catra jumped up, adding in a summer-sault mid-air for effect of course.

"Go and due your duty in the name of Horde Prime."

"In the name of Horde Prime," Catra, Lonnie, Kyle, (and Rogelio through rawrs,) responded automatically.

Who even is Horde Prime?

Catra shrugged, it had always been part of formal protocol for any mission departing, or at any event, a monotone meaningless innovation she had memorized since...since she'd come to the Horde as a kitten. As commonplace as "Yes Hordak," and with lesser actual meaning. Rogelio revved the engine. Kyle let out a squeak and Lonnie steered the sails until they were speeding away from the noxious fumes of the Fright Zone. Before the smoke stacks disappeared in a cloud of haze, Catra thought she could see a red claw, waving them goodbye.

Beginning to think I shouldn't have dozed off during that briefing, Catra thought, pausing after recording Log 02 of the mission. Now that the woods were insight, she'd scanned an initial map, plus activated magic sensors and now her own eyes roved over the treetops, trying to recall the history and significance of the woodlands. It was the border of the Fright Zone, separating the Horde's stronghold from the rest of the Etherian Kingdoms, with Thaymore being the closest settlement and Plumeria the closest princess kingdom. But beyond ghost stories and training simulations, the Whispering Woods was largely an enigma.

"Take us lower," she ordered Lonnie at the helm.

"Lower?" She balked, "we'll crash!"

"No, we won't, we need a better visual on what's beneath the trees, not just the trees themselves!"

Rogelio grunted something, but refused to concede.

"Just do it! You want me to put in a good word for you don't you?"

The lizard guy snorted but looked at Lonnie who said nothing. The skiff did however, gently begin to glide downward, closer and closer to the dense canopy.

"Everyone hang on!" Kyle screeched, bracing himself.

Catra dug her clung her claws around the metal of the skiff's starboard side, not so much as flinching as the skiff dipped low, branches whooshing by.

"What's that smell? It's like, rich and clean!"

"That's fresh air you dipshit," Lonnie sneered, the skiff evened out, now effortlessly gliding just above the forest floor. Branches still hung low, but Lonnie tilted the skiff this way and that to adjust.

Catra looked around in awe,

This is the Whispering Woods?

She'd only ever seen it from the inside of a transport or a tank or briefly on some mission to squander outposts. Never took in it's actual landscape, never recorded it's rustling leaves or dull colors of purples and pinks.

It's...it's beautiful?

She sucked in the air, ripe with earth and cool and so many smells.

Loamy and sweet….deep and pretty. Like the very breeze is alive and….shit the data!

Jolted from her reverie, Catra snapped back into duty, taking out the data pad and turning it on again, activating the camera and magic detector. The pad beeped on and off and on and off as it mapped the forest looking for any sign of movement.

"Rawwwwr!!!"

Catra spun, Kyle screamed, the skiff lurched forward, spinning, Lonnie shouted something.

"What the hell?!"

"Rawwr! Ra!"

Catra nearly shrieked as the skiff lurched again, boxes of supplies falling overboard with each jerking propulsion.

"What the hell is happening?!" She seethed, trying to quell her nausea.

"Skiff must've hit a large root or something! These trees grow all weird, and one of the branches tore into our sail!" Lonnie reported from the helm, still trying to regain control.

Shit, shit shit! Fuck these woods! Okay, we can stabilize it, land and assess the damage, We can….

Catra looked around in horror at the cart of items spilling over the bow.

And the data pad, we have the repor….FUCK!

Her fingers grazed her belt where the pad should've been. Nothing. The deck of the ship, nothing.

"Turn this thing around!"

"Are you nuts?!" Lonnie fought with the stuck steering device as the skiff huffed and puffed forward and down, buckling and swerving.

"The data pad must've fallen out!" Catra's voice cracked, "all our data is on there! All our maps!"

"Catra it's gone! We have to land and see what damage we took! Make Sure no one's hurt!"

The skiff slammed against a tree, Kyle was thrown back, teetering of the leeward side, he screamed, arms flailing, Rogelio dove, catching him by his shirt in his teeth and hauling him back up.

"W...we are g...getting that data!" Catra snarled,

"No!" Lonnie held firm.

The skiff swooped low again, scrapping against the trees.

If they won't go back for it…

Catra crawled to the edge of the back of the skiff, looking down over the lip of the metal where the rockets shot out fuel.

"Catra!!! What are you?!"

She jumped. Tucking, rolling, free-falling and slammed into the solid ground. Hard rocks battered against her face, she curled tighter, her momentum sending her rolling through the brush. She pinched her eyes tight, trying to protect herself.

Curl, curled nice and tight like a ball, like you did when you were little so Shadow Weaver's magic doesn't spread as fast. Make yourself small.

She rolled and rolled, and rolled and...stopped.

Panting, Catra slowly lowered her arms, blinking away the blurry outlines of the trees.

"I'm okay," she whispered, wiggling her tail, then her feet, then her legs. Moving slowly, deliberately. No sign of the skiff as far as she could see. The scent of burning fuel was distant and thin, but there.

I...I'll find them later. A...after I find the data pad. That's it, one step at a time Catra.

She trained her eyes over the leafy patterned forest floor. The smell of the woods carried on the breeze now engulfed her entirely, even as she began to search for the data pad.

"Where the hell, it could be anywhere!"

Catra knocked the branches out of the way, searching desperately for any sign of it.

It must've been on when I dropped it so it would be beeping, blinking.

She listened for any sign of it, nothing. Only her own steps and the occasional rustle of branches in the wind.

...and I don't even have a weapon. If Princesses, or some creature come I can't…

Something in the distance, light. The light from the mapping tech on the data pad.

Yes! Yes that must be it!

With renewed determination, Catra walked through the woods towards the unnatural glow.

"This could still work out! I'll get the data pad, map everything on foot as I find the skiff, file it all in the log, we'll get ourselves mended and fix the skiff and head back. Hordak will be even more impressed when he sees all I went through to get this report back safe…."

Catra stopped in her tracks, words stolen from her in an instant.

There, in the clearing, something did glow. But it was no data pad.

"A...a sword?"

A lone spectacular sword, its blade buried in the earth Glowing with a light all on it's own. Casting colors along a sheer backdrop of earth-worn rock. Catra's eyes widened, her pupils growing larger, she stepped into the clearing, tail raised.

"What…?

A pulse, it smelled...different, like the rest of the woods but deeper. Something she'd never smelled before and yet, knew from some secret hiding inaccessible part of her being. Catra glanced about the edges of the clearing for any sign of monster or princess but nothing. The sword pulled her attention back as if it had a gravity of its own. The multicolored lights spun and danced, reflecting off her bare feet as she crept closer.

"What in Horde Prime's name…?"

Catra held her breath, the lights, so brilliant, the clearing so still as if it were hallowed ground. She eyed it suspiciously,

This could be a trap, it is a trap, it's most definitely a trap. Some weapon of the princesses, or...something even worse...but…

She reached out one hand towards the blade, it's golden pommel and pure blue gem calling to her curiosity. Calling to that profound part of herself. To her possibility, To something greater than what she believed herself to be.

Catra held her breath, and let one tentative claw grace the center of the gem.

A blinding white light exploded forth, sending her falling backward onto the damp...no, *dry solid ground? Floor?*

She blinked, pupils thinning in the sudden dark. Catra's hair stood on end, she snarled, ready to fight.

"Hello Catra,"

"Who's there?!"

Out of the thin darkness, tiny purple orbs glowed, illuminating not trees, but geometrics halls of sharp angles and impossibly infinite corridors. More purples and blues showed all around her, rippling as if underwater.

But I'm not underwater, she took a deep shaking breath just to be sure, her heart hammering wildly in her chest.

The lights showed strange etching on the walls around her, intricate circles of various sizes, connected by straight lines in odd patterns she'd never seen before.

"Where am I?" Catra tried to snarl, slowly getting to her feet, claws out. A beam of light propelled down before her from some unknown source. She shielded her eyes with her arms, her tail lashing madly. All around her lights danced and the smell in the clearing that surrounded the sword now emanated everywhere. Silhouetted against the backdrop of pure white, came an imposing figure, taller than Catra by a length at least.

“I have been waiting for a long time for you,” It spoke in a monotone voice. “But I could not reach you until you forged your connection with the sword.”

Catra slowly let her arms down, but kept her claws out, staring in disbelief.

“You sent the sword?!”

“The sword is meant for you.”

She couldn’t help a tiny gasp as the sword itself materialized before her, suspended in mid-air. Glowing and waiting to be taken.

“Etheria has need of you Catra, will you answer its call?

I...I’ve never been needed…by anyone, for anything.

She stared at the sword, it’s magnificent blade. The figure before her, it’s face unknowable in the pure black of the silhouette, spoke again.

“Will you fight for the honor of GraySkull?”

“What are you talking about?! What...what is Gray Skull, you’re not making any sense! I don’t understand!”

“You will,” the figure promised.

Catra flinched, the little birthmark on her wrist...it seemed to..glow.

No! No! It’s just the lights in here! The weird lights! This is all so weird!

Catra watched the figure slowly disappear, disintegrating back into the light.

“Wait!!!”

Catra beseeched, was she crying?

“Who are you?!”

The monotone voice was more distant now, being consumed by the garish white light.

“I am the Shera of old and I am gone.”

The Shera of Old

Chapter Summary

Catra meets the Shera of old..and two additional... friends(?)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Ooof!" Catra tumbled to the ground, blown back by sheer force of the light, of that creature, the Shera of old. She grit her teeth, a rock hitting her in the back as she quickly rolled and crouched on all fours, her ears swiveling to catch any sound. Her tail raised, claws still out, gripping the dirt. The sword, it hovered before her just as it had in that weird place with the script.

Shadow Weaver is going to have my ass for this, she thought with dread. Catra stood shakily, sniffing the air. Something had changed, a noise from the bushes.

Shera?

"On your knees Horde Scuuum!"

A pink sparkling cloud materialized in an instant. Catra hissed, darting out of the way, making for the bushes.

"Hey you! S…stop!"

Two golden arrowheads stopped her in her tracks, a boy tightened his bow, glaring down at her, but she could smell traces of fear on him too.

He's no Horde soldier, and the girl…she must be…a princess?!

"Ahhhh!" The princess in question slammed her in the back, breath knocked from her lungs. Catra caught herself before falling face first. Arrow boy let out a gasp, twisting to get out of her way.

Catra clawed at the rough ground, fisting a handful of dirt and flung it at the princesses face. The glint of the sword still shown, Catra spied it from the corner of her eye, it's magnificent glow, somehow calm and latent in the chaos. She swiped at the princesses' next attack, easily dodging the little cloud of sparkles that seemed to follow wherever she went.

"Bow! The sword!"

Catra lunged for it, palms easily gripping the handle and swung at the oncoming arrows. They skidded off the blade in an instant, knocked back as if the sword had a power and momentum of its own. She swung again, her arms arching naturally with the blade. It fit perfectly, not nearly as heavy as it should be. Supple and lithe despite it's broadness, though Catra knew very little about swords. The Horde mostly relied on stun batons, electric rods and bots to inflict harm on their opponents.

This…glowing…it's…is it…?

A strange wave pulsed through her fingers, to her hands and up her arms, into her whole body it seemed. Thrumming with strength from the sword, light, that awesome mysterious energy that had intrigued her in the first place, now, she felt it all around her, *within* her.

Is this magi…

"Stand down Horde Scum!"

The sparkly princess shouted, inches from the tip of the blade. Her eyes brimmed with rage, her hands balled in two sparkly fists of rage. Catra adjusted her grip, baring her fangs. Her right ear twitched, the arrow boy was there in her periphery, an arrow drawn and ready.

"I am Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon," the angry puffball announced. "Put down the sword! You are hereby a captive of the Princess Alliance. You will be brought before Queen…"

“You sure I’m the captive?” Catra seemed to find her voice again through the momentous whirlwind of events. “Because I’m the one holding the magic sword, and all you’ve done is try to scare me with your little glitter trick and a couple of bouncy arrows.”

She grinned watching the Princess, Glimmer’s, face contort in indignant rage.

“You will be brought before Queen Angella and Leader of the Rebellion at Castle Brightmoon!”

Brightmoon? The most powerful kingdom in Etheria. If I could get intel on that for Hordak….that would be a thousand times better than the Whispering Woods!

“A..are you even listening to me?!” Glimmer barked. Catra smirked, taking one hand off the sword and examining any damage to her claws.

“What was that Sparkles? I wasn’t listening.”

“You’re such a pain!” Sparkles seethed, “put the sword down, you’re coming with us!”

“Fine,” Catra directed her vitriol towards the princess once more, “I’ll come with you. But I’m keeping the sword.”

“No! You’re not!” Glimmer stalked forward, her magic sparkly fists ready to release their energy. Catra gripped the sword tighter, one ear still tracking the guy with the arrows.

“Don’t come any closer princess, unless you want a really botched haircut!” Catra threatened, raising the blade to strike. It guided her, pulled her forward, pulsed with that energy she could only assume was magic, it wanted to strike Glimmer. It wanted to fight.

“No!”

“Give it!”

"I'll slice you princess, don't push it!"

"Try me!"

"I will!"

"Ahhh!"

Catra whipped around, Bow let loose another arrow. She made to parry with the sword and stopped, watching the arrows arch up, towards the trees then…

What the shit?

The massive, spider thing crushed Bow's arrows in a single snap of serrated teeth. It's multi-legged form driving into the forest floor, shaking the ground. It roared, coming closer.

"Arrhh!" Glimmer bolted forward, sending sparks of her magic at it with both hands, one after the other in quick succession.

Not bad for a princess, Catra mused, before letting out a small yelp, as she jumped away just in time. The spider's sharp leg missed her by an inch. She landed next to Bow, holding the sword to her chest.

"Arrhh!" Glimmer bellowed, whipping at the monster with magic.

Fight it! See what the sword can really do!

Catra glanced down at it, tail twitching as a spark of blue lightning danced around the blade before fizzing out.

"Glimmer!"

Beside her Bow shouted, Catra looked up, hissing. Glimmer shrieked, flying through the air and slamming into the large trunk of a tree. She groaned, sliding down to the ground listlessly.

Shit, shit, shit! Use the sword!

The spider took a swing at Bow, who frantically released arrows from his quiver as fast as he could, trying to back pedal towards Glimmer.

"Don't turn your back on it you idiot!"

Catra growled, watching Bow reach for an empty quiver. He panicked, running to the princess, the spider high on his heel. It roared again, spitting a jet of webbing. Bow stumbled, falling on top of his comrade.

They're both idiots!

Catra took a deep breath, held it, then dived forward, sliding between Bow and the oncoming assault. The spider attempted to spit at her, she dodged, it followed. She swung the sword again, almost as naturally as if it were her own claws. The bug reared, it's stinking fowl mouth opening again. It poised it's claw to strike and came down with a heavy force. On instinct, Catra brought the blade up, over her head,

KKKKKssshhhh!

Vibrations quivered along the sword length, up her arms, to her body, the swimming dizziness in her head.

"Catra!"

The sword exploded with white light, fading into black. A planet, the whole dimension of Despondos, Etheria, the three moons.

"Catra!"

Vision dissolved again, a shimmering, pastel castle built into the side of a cliff, Brightmoon?

"Catra!

A fiery comet crashing in an orange, inhospitable desert.

“Catra!”

A glowing blue and purple structure, rising out of the woods. Etched in the same geometric script. Two doors opening, the beam of white light, that same figure. This time in full color. It was a woman, tall and grand. Her armor white and golden. Bright radiant yellow hair billowing down her back in a single ponytail, the tiara on adorning her head winged and regal. Those eyes… those electric blue eyes…bore into her very soul.

“Catra,” the warrior, Shera, intoned.

“Will you fight for the honor of GraySkull?” Honor of GraySkull, honor of GraySkull, honor of GraySkull, honor of…”

The Shera of old faded, the figure dissolved, replaced this time with another, holding the sword aloft in a rim of flashing sunlight. The shadow’s back turned to her, but there was something different. This warrior, another Shera? Had a different cape, that hugged the base of her neck,,and…were those….feline ears?

Catra’s scenes suddenly returned to her, flashing her back to the present. The weight of the spider’s limb pressing against the blade.

“Uuuurrghhh!” Catra grunted, the claws on her feet digging into the earth, her arms aching with pressure.

‘ *Shit…shit..what do I…?!*

“For the honor of GraySkull,” Shera had said.

“F…for the honor of GraySkull!” Catra screamed, as if the air in her lungs were burning. The magic of the sword exploded fourth, that same brilliant light consuming her. Catra pinched her eyes shut, instinctively crouching, bracing for a blow, for some agony to wrack through her. Magic, power, warm but not burning, coursing through her arms, to the tip of her tail, down her legs, pounding in her chest.

So this is the magic of Etheria,

Catra opened her eyes, the pressure of the spider lifted.

"What the…"

The monster only blinked before her, still she held the sword, but lowered it. The thing chittered at her, the spikes covering his body seeming to deflate before her eyes. The spider glanced around, then shuttered, and scuttled back into the woods. Catra's breath shuttered, watching it flee. The light around her still glowed.

"Wh..what's happening?"

She shook her head, it felt lighter, she reached up with her free hand, feeling the edge of her own cheeks.

My mask?!

Catra stared down at her own heaving chest, eyes wide. Her torn, dirty red uniform was gone…replaced by white and ruby red apparel. The same odd star pattern that adorned the elder Shera's armor now etched on her own chest. She turned experimentally to the side, catching a glimpse of a cape that cinched just below her neck and swept back over her shoulders.. Her hand traveled gently upward, and stopped. Her mask no longer curved around her face but was affixed to where her ears connected with her head, two pointed edges curving above and below to form a sharp crescent that framed her temples.

At least I'm not wearing a skirt,

Catra noticed her ripped leggings were mostly the same, only now white, still torn at the knees and open to allow her feet some freedom. Even her hair, which usually fell to the middle of her shoulders, now fell low, brown locks swooping her lower back.

How the hell do I even change b…back? Why did that spider thing suddenly run off? How do I get out of this out…

Pink glitter rained down on her, and Catra leapt to the side, only for Glimmer to instantly teleport before her. Purplish eyes so wide Catra could see her own new absurd reflection in them.

"You're Shera?!

"What the hell is Shera?!" Catra backed up, leveling the sword. She winced, as white light and sparkling magic flared again. When she put her arms down, she saw her usual red dirty uniform. Her mask had returned.

Bow dashed up to her in an instant,

"Glimmer! She doesn't know about Shera?! The legendary champion of Etheria? The Princess of Power?!"

"Look, it's been a very strange, messed up day," Catra tried, still balancing the sword in her hand. Glimmer only smirked,

"Never thought Shera would come from the Horde."

The Horde! The squad is probably still stranded out there, if Lonnie gets back before me I'm dead. Even if I bring back enough dirt on the princesses Shadow Weaver will still think I failed….Shera? The Shera of old…those places, that castle, is that where the old Shera is? She must know what this is about.

Thousands of incoherent thoughts flew through Catra's mind in a matter of seconds, tuning out Glimmer and Bow's squabbling.

"Take me to the weird shinny castle in the woods!"

"What castle?" Glimmer demanded hotly. Bow placed a hand on the princess's shoulder, seeming to cool her.

"I think she means the Crystal Castle? That old First Ones ruin?"

"A…As Shera I demand you take me there. Now!"

Glimmer only snorted, waving Bow's hand away.

“You’re the *worst,* and you're from the Horde, how can *you* be Shera?”

The bubbling anxiety and uncertainty finally reached its boiling point. Catra lowered the sword, her cool brash demeanor slipping.

“I don’t know, okay?! I don’t know anything! Up until moments ago I was on a routine mission and since Lonnie crashed our skiff I’ve touched a weirdo glowing magic sword that showed me weirdo magic kingdoms and a weirdo First Ones temple and a weirdo glowing Shera lady who asked me if I would fight for the honor of GraySkull, whatever that is! Got attacked by a spider, ran into you freaks, had my entire body changed and then changed back all because of the weirdo sword, so take me to that castle and let me talk to this other Shera so I can figure out what the hell is going on!”

She panted for breath, hair on edge.

“You could’ve asked nicely.” Glimmer quipped.

“We can take you there,” Bow interjected. “But we have to be careful, there are Horde patrols out, and we’re…we’re going to be ready for anything so don’t even think about trying anything!”

Catra nodded, her exhaustion and bewilderment robbed her of any energy for quipps or snark, at least at the moment.

Glimmer folded her arms, glaring daggers at her still.

—

They better know where they’re going, Catra fumed, pushing back another branch from her face. She lost track of how long they had walked, what with Glimmer’s eyes on her back and Bow’s constant commentary about how “the Horde is evil,” and “we’re trying to protect the people of Etheria,” and “we could all be friends if we cast aside our differences.” Catra only thought of the Shera of old, her energy, her magic. It quickened her blood each time she

recalled the warrior woman. Her ethereal presence and vague words of destiny.

If I touched the sword, used the sword, said those words, whatever the hell GraySkull is….and I changed….then does that… m..make me….?

"We're here!" Bow announced, flinging his arms wide in excitement. Catra looked up, indeed the strange castle from her vision, only it wasn't nearly as clean and grand. Licon and vines crept along it's walls, the stone worn and weathered with cracks.

"This is it?"

"Yeah, an old First Ones temple," Bow crept closer, brushing off a stray patch of dirt along the threshold. "My dads, they're scholars and they study the ancient technology of the First Ones, the original settlers of Etheria. I always knew there were ruins around but I never knew Shera was connected to them."

"Shhh Bow You're giving the enemy all our intel!"

Bow didn't appear to be bothered by it, as he turned to Catra expectantly.

"There's some sort of password on the door," she squinted, reading over the lines and small circles. Easy as any script.

"You can read that?" Glimmer pressed, Catra shrugged, peering closer, claws picking at the crusted earth embedded in the carvings.

"What does it say?"

She looked closer, then stepped back,

"It says….eternia?"

How can I even read that? She'd never seen it before in her life, not even in briefings and reports back from Princess strongholds

but…the words came to her as natural as any language she'd ever known.

On cue, the stone began to glow, filling out the carved words of the First Ones to illuminate the triangular doorway. It opened immediately, to a black chasm.

A shiver went through Catra's spine making her tail switch nervously. The little birthmark on her wrist itching.

"Well Horde Scum, lead the way," Glimmer teased, she made to shove Catra forward but she bristled, hissing and strode through, into the eerie dark.

"What do you think this place used to be?"

Glimmer's hands lit up into a sparkly ball of pink magic, making Catra flinch on instinct. Magic coming from the palms of someone's hands was usually coming for her. Her eyes adjusted to the dim lighting, taking in long rows of columns on either side of them, down what appeared to be a hallway.

"This way," she held the sword pointed before her, "follow me."

For once, the princess didn't argue. Catra walked briskly, her eyes scanning the sides of the seemingly endless corridor for any signs of a threat.

Remember the training exercises, right, left, up, down. When in doubt just use the sword.

"Thanks for saving us by the way," Arrow boy sidled up beside her.

"Psh, I didn't save you. I wanted the sword arlight?"

"Are you sure it's not because you secretly like us?"

She rolled her eyes,

“I don’t like you,” she pushed his shoulder for emphasis, shoving past him down the long hallway.

“I’m Bow by the way, and you already met Glimmer.”

“.....Catra,” she muttered begrudgingly.

“Woah, look at that!” Glimmer announced; she'd taken up a pace ahead of them.

Some sort of mureal? The same First One’s script, Catra approached with caution. From the floor to the ceiling towered an incredible carving,

The woman from that vision, Catra took in the site of her long cape, and the sword clutched in front of her. Though this carving bore no facial features or expression, the triangular angles of the warriors armor were unmistakable and the same elegant headdress. Catra winced, glancing down.

What the hell is it…?

The little mark over her wrist pulsed with light. She scratched at it lightly in wonder.

“That look like you!” Bow exclaimed, “well, not exactly like you but….kinda. I mean your tiara was a little different but,”

“It’s not a tiara!” Catra growled. Her heart beat erratically, the mark on her arm continuing to pulse, it itched. Itched towards something. Her tail swooshed in anxiety back and forth.

“Whatever it is, it looks enough like you. What does that inscription say?” Glimmer pointed to the markings beneath the murial. Catra squinted,

“It says, Shera.”

Light flickered to life, illuminating the script. Sending a cascade of light purple brightness across the mural, traveling upward and

outward to fill the entire slab. Bow, Glimmer and Catra jumped backward, a strange semi-luminescent figure appearing before them.

It's her! The Shera of old.

Catra held her wrist to her chest, her thumb circling around her mark with one hand rhythmically. Images flashed before her again.

The sword, a young girl, blonde hair, blue eyes, red jacket. A girl fighting horde soldiers. Hordak? A strange circular disk that sucked pieces of metal and debris into it with no return. Shera frantically trying to find a way to stop it. More of Hordak, no….different. Beings that looked like him but slightly smaller, dressed in white. A larger one, with odd tentacles for hair, glowing green eyes. Shera again, wandering some similar hallway. An explosion. Screaming.

"Catra! Are you okay?!" Bow's hands gripped her shoulders. She'd fallen to the ground somehow.

"Shera," the voice coaxed her from her daze. Catra looked up at the immaculate warrior. "Welcome Shera of Etheria." The name and title sent Catra's stomach squirming.

"Who are you?!" Glimmer demanded. Catra shrugged Bow's shoulder off, picking herself up.

"I am the Shera of old."

"We already knew that," Catra snapped, lifting the sword once more pointing it at the flickering hologram. Still, something gnawed at Catra's insides.

I know her…knew her….? No, that's crazy. No, I've definitely known her.

Something compelled the fact. Something about those shining blue eyes. There was more to them. Catra knew it, knew it as

surely as she could feel the tingling on the mark of her wrist.

“What’s your actual name? Not Shera, your normal name.”

The hologram blinked, it’s previously placid expression shifting from unreadable to a flare of confusion. The edge of her mouth twitched, her brows raised. The fingers around the grip of her sword moved ever so slightly. Catra’s heart fluttered, seeing true genuine emotion for the first time from this odd being.

“A…Adora.”

Adora.

The sound of her name made Catra tremble. Her blood quickening.

“And you used to be Shera?” Glimmer asked. Adora’s phosphorescent eyes did not break from Catra’s gaze even as she nodded.

“Yes,…a…a long time ago.”

“If you were Shera,” Bow began, “does that mean Catra is Shera now?”

Adora’s mouth tilted to a smile, her eyes shimmering. Catra blinked, trying not to lose herself in them. Luckily Arrow Boy and Sparkles were full of chitter chatter, she couldn’t speak even if she tried. Every hair on her head, ears and tail was raised. The magic from the sword, and from Adora nearly paralyzing her with their power. The endless throbbing of light around her birthmark pulling her closer to this Adora.

“Yes, Ca…Catra is Shera now. She took up the sword, she spoke the words.” Catra couldn’t help but detect a soft melancholy in Adora’s tone. “ The magic of Etheria must be freed from the Heart. I am sorry I could not do it. Prime was too strong.” Her image flickered, and Catra’s chest seized with panic.

No! Don't go! Please, stay!

"I…it's okay," Bow whispered, reaching out a hand as if to comfort this odd Adora. Her image flickered in and out.

"I tried to stop him, tried to prevent it from happening but I was weak," Adora looked at the sword in her hands. It appeared trapped there. She appeared trapped. Catra tried to re-conjure the images she'd seen,

The girl in the red jacket with the sword, that was Adora!

"Listen, i…it's okay," Catra managed to regain her speech. "Just tell me what happened."

Adora looked up at her again, those sad eyes cutting through Catra's jaded heart like butter. She rubbed her birthmark harder, trying to distribute the strange warm feeling there.

"I found the sword in the Whispering Woods, became Shera, pledged myself to the rebellion. Queen Angella and King Micha."

Catra cast a glance towards Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon, who's jaw nearly fell to the floor.

"I had no idea," she whispered.

Adora nodded, resolute.

"That's for the best. Together we tried to build the princess alliance but….he came too quickly, we weren't strong enough."

"Who's he?" Bow whispered, looking nearly as horrified as Catra felt.

"Horde Prime," Catra said the words without thinking.

The one that looked like Hordak but larger, with the eyes and the robes .

Adora turned sharply to her, straightening from her slump.

“Yes. Horde Prime. He came through a portal and I tried to stop it but….but there were too many mistakes. Most of them mine,” her voice cracked. Catra thought she saw a tiny tear ebb at the corner of Adora’s eyes. Her image flickered out and then back in, but duller now. Catra’s legs wobbled, she gripped the sword tighter. Trying to ground herself from the energy all around her.

“What happened?”

Adora’s image flickered again, Catra reached outward on impulse, her fingers sliding through the light of the woman’s form. She grasped at air.

“I’m sorry,” Adora cried. “I wish I could be more helpful. Catra…I tried to protect you, to make it so you’d never have to go through what I did but I…I failed you.” Adora’s face crumbled before Catra’s eyes into a mess of tears. Her form fuzzing out and back in like a weakly fading pulse.

“Catra, take the sword, it is no longer tied to the First Ones, but I am. You must be careful, you must warn the princesses and all who remain on Etheria. Prime will be back and when he comes….you…you must be careful. P…p…pl…pleas….C…Catra!”

The weeping warrior faded out and disappeared entirely.

Catra wiped her eyes before Glimmer or Bow could see. Her heart hammering in her chest. She changed her grip on the sword, palms sweaty, ears low and tail between her legs. She glanced at the mark on her wrist.

It has to be something more than a birthmark…? A...Adora, she was the Shera before me. But she…she’s dead? Impossible, I…I felt her. I wouldn’t be able to feel her if she were dead right?! She was so sad…so scared.

“Well, that was odd,” Bow stared at her like she had three heads. Catra ignored him, her thoughts focused singularly on Adora.

Adora, Adora, Adora.

An inexplicable warmth took over her at the thought of that name. Along with a twinge of sorrow deep in her heart. She watched the magical light surrounding that strange mark fade away, receding. Instantly missing it.

"My mom never told me about the failed rebellion, or anyone named Horde Prime. I only heard legends of Shera, but no one named Adora," Glimmer processed out loud in disbelief.

"What do we do now?" Bow asked softly.

Get Adora back! We have to get her back.

Catra swallowed, shaking her head, steeling herself. Willing herself to get a grip.

Standing here feeling sorry for her isn't going to help her. She said to warn the Princess Alliance…everyone on Etheria, does that include the Horde?

Scorpia's sanguine smile came to her mind, an icy stab of guilt penetrating through her chest.

"We have to get out of here," she turned to Bow and Glimmer, running a hand through her hair attempting to pat it down.

"Sparkles, you were able to teleport around when we were fighting. Can you teleport us out of here?"

Glimmer's eyes were hard but they no longer glared so callously. She nodded, determined.

"Glimmer no! You're not supposed to,"

The princess's arm went around her wrist, tugging her forward. There was a strange shimmer of pink sparkle all around her, magic, but different from Shera's. Catra felt herself levitate off the ground, whole body going rigid with panic. Bow's screams were

muffled and their faces dissolved into pink. She was spinning, vision blurring and stomach churning before an audible "poof!" and a "thud," as her bum connected with the forest floor.

"N…never do that without telling me again," Catra coughed, pressing her free hand to a roiling stomach. She tried to swallow back the bile in her mouth.

"Sorry," Glimmer breathed. Catra turned, the princess slumped against a large tree, her face pale.

"Glimmer! I told you not to teleport us out like that! You've never done it before!" Bow was at her side in an instant, running his hands along her arms. Checking her over.

I couldn't touch Shera…my hand just went through her. Catra glanced down at her mark. *What would it be like….to touch Adora?*

She forced away any implications of that question, any secret wondering of the astute familiarity and odd longing for the woman she'd just met through a hologram. Absurd wasn't it? This whole day was absurd. She cleared her throat, walking over to Glimmer and crouching.

"You alright there Sparkles?"

"I'm fine, I just….need to push through."

Bow scowled, pressing a hand to her forehead.

"You need to rest. We'll go back to Brightmoon and have you recharge. Your mom can meet Catra and this whole thing will get set straight."

"You sure this whole that's a good idea?" Catra tried to suppress the growl in her voice. "I'm Horde Scum, remember?"

Glimmer gave a short laugh, forcing herself upward, leaning ever so slightly on Bow's arm.

Catra looked down at the sword, it's magical potential in her hands.

Adora, I know her from something, somewhere…if I go with them, I can see her again. I can figure out what this Shera thing is all about. Warn the Horde…but…Shadow Weaver…

The thought of the sorceress awakened images from the depths of her consciousness.

Unbearable fiery red pain, shadows chasing her no matter where she hid.

"I will dispose of you myself."

"Insolent child!"

Magic electrifying through her body, burning her bones.

"Stop!"

Her head spun.

"Please! Stop!

Shadow Weaver spinning her magic, making her cower and cry. Seeking refuge in dark lonesome corners. Trying to wipe her tears before anyone caught her. Shadow Weaver who tormented Catra since she was old enough to withstand a blow. Trying to make herself small and silent, complicit. Everything Shera was not. As Shera…she could be more than a mewling kitten in a box. More than a plaything for Shadow Weaver's rage. She could be bright, respected, revered even.

Alright Catra, this is the first step. You can do this. Adora if you do, you'll get to see Adora again.

"Fine," she conceited, trying to suppress the lingering sickening thoughts of Shadow Weaver's last toriment. "I'll go meet with

your mom. But you need to promise me this isn't some sort of elaborate trap."

Glimmer huffed, crossing her arms over her chest,

"Did that hologram back there seem like a trap?"

No. It felt like….a realization.

"I'll give you that one Sparkles. Now come on, can't wait to see the look on the Queen's face when you drag in a Horde soldier who's secretly Shera."

Catra smirked, gesturing for the princess and Arrow Boy to lead the way.

Well this is going better than expected,

Catra dared to think, leveling her eyes with Queen Angella, refusing to look away. The whole of Brightmoon's royal court glaring at her despite Bow and (surprisingly) Glimmer's advocacy on her behalf. The court of Brightmoon was as glittering and gross and Catra expected of the most powerful kingdom in the rebellion. Their endless fountains and lavish pastel halls made her want to gag. But she squared her stance and kept her mouth shut, at least for now. The other princesses of their realms sat beside Queen Angella, she recognized their kingdoms from cadet training.

Plumeria, the Kingdom of Snows, Selinius, so on and so forth.

"My daughter says you are the next Shera," nothing in the queen's tone betrayed any knowledge of a prior one. "Prove yourself,"

Should've known that was coming.

Catra took a deep breath, chasing the doubt in her mind.

Please work.

She raised the sword above her head to the lofty vaulted ceiling.

"For the Honor of GraySkull!"

She held her breath as the magic rippled over her, enveloping her in light. Her cape rippled down her back, her headdress now carrying more weight around her ears, she opened her eyes to Queen Angella's wide eyes and the gasps of the court. Catra held the sword in both hands.

"I am Shera. I took the sword," she borrowed Adora's statement, lending her confidence, "I spoke the words. There is a great evil coming, worse than the Horde. I don't know exactly who or when, but if I really am Shera….you're going to need me."

The Queen's eyes, hard as ice like Glimmer's, ran over Catra, even in her Shera form, she shivered inwardly.

"A great evil you say?"

"Yes."

That's what Adora said.

"I knew of a Shera much like yourself."

Catra's ears pricked forward.

"She came to us many years ago when the Horde had all but defeated us. She faced a great evil too, perhaps it is the one you warn us of now. We thought we could defeat the Galactic Horde… Shera herself attempted to take down their leader…but the Heart of Etheria was too strong in the end," Angella's face remained stone. "She perished, and we never recovered her legendary sword. We assumed all was lost."

Did you even know her name? Did you call her Adora, or was she just Shera to you?

Hatred of the Princesses and their rebellion threatened to surface in her face, but Angella continued.

"I see now she has returned to us, in the form of a Horde Soldier. Would you pledge yourself to us? Fight against those you once stood with? Will you stand with us to meet this evil whoever it may be?"

I'm not pledging myself to anyone, Catra vowed to herself. All she'd ever done for the Horde was thankless, there was no reason for the Princess Alliance to be any different. There was no one you could be beheld to but yourself.

"I'm not taking sides," she answered, shifting her stance, feeling her height and power, cape and long hair rustling. "I'm on the side of all Etheria."

Angella raised a brow.

"Glimmer, you would vouch for her? And take responsibility for her?"

Catra waited for the resounding no.

"I will," the princess answered pertly. Catra let out a little breath of disbelief, smiling to herself.

"Then so be it," Angella intoned. "You are welcome here Shera, Princess of Power. May we work together to take down this threat, once and for all."

"Shera! Shera! Shera! Shera!"

Catra's ears twitched at the applause, she beamed, and thrust the sword aloft with their chants. A rising lightness in her heart.

"Wooooh!" Bow clapped, "Go Catra! Our new Shera!"

Catra beamed, closing her eyes again and allowing herself a happy sigh as she settled back into normal form.

“Make yourself comfortable for the rest of the day and get settled. In the morning we will have much to discuss.”

“I need to go back to that First Ones place,” Catra fastened the sword to the belt Bow fetched her from one of the wardrobes.

“Catra, It’s only been like three days, you need to stay here and help us get a better grip on this threat.”

She shook her head, pacing restlessly around the room she’d been given. It was too large, too comfortable.

“I know this might come as a surprise to you, but I don’t actually know what I’m doing.”

“Oh that much is obvious,” Glimmer poofed into the room unannounced. “I knew you’ve been winging it this entire time.”

Catra hissed, baring her fangs but settled for sticking her tongue out as rebuke.

“So, I need to go back to that weird shiny place and figure out how Adora managed to face the threat before so that we can face it now!”

How were these people not entirely conquered already?!

“Shera failed,” Glimmer flopped down on the couch filled with pillows Catra had yet to use, (opting instead for either the rim of the balcony or the rafters). “She couldn’t defeat this evil the first time, that’s why…”

“That wasn’t her fault!” Catra barked, rounding on her, ears flattening. Her body shimmered with magic, threatening to transform. “Sorry,” she flexed her fingers, claws retracting. “That wasn’t her fault, but I need to go there and find her and talk to her so we can know what to prepare for.”

"I really think it's best if you stay here," Bow apologetically mumbled, he fiddled with a data pad. "The Horde has been increasing their patrols lately, and Queen Angella called a meeting with the Princess Alliance this afternoon. She'll want you there."

Always these endless meetings, maybe the rebellion isn't so different from the Horde after all.

"I'm not sitting around here talking," Catra's tail lashed. "I'm going. Now are you with me or not?"

She looked between Glimmer and Bow, who glanced between themselves, speaking in that unspoken language only the two of them seemed to understand.

"Alright Horde Scum," Glimmer signed, exasperated. "We'll cover for you."

Catra nodded, her ears perking, she softened her gaze.

"Thanks Glimmer."

The princess smiled at her for the first time, almost genuine.

"Thank you, really. I'll be back tonight okay? I owe you one."

Glimmer shrugged, waving her off.

Catra checked her sword, waved and leapt out the window, giggling for the first time in a long time at Bow's horrified gasp.

Catra crouched, the tip of the sword pushing a stray branch out the way. She looked up, ears alert, tail flicking. The Horde skiff gilded too close to the ground for comfort.

Smells different than the old one, even in her Shera form, Catrai's tail coiled in dread. She waited, until the stench of iron and sulfur

of the skiff gave way to the fresh vivacious woods once more.

That was far too close.

She kept her Shera form as she snuck through the trees, darting over large roots, through the undergrowth to the Crystal Castle.

"Alright, please work like you did the first time," she took a deep breath, scanning one last time for any prying eyes or Horde craft. "Eternia."

Again the door glowed, opening just like it had before. This time Catra dashed forward without hesitation. The little mark on her wrist glowing as she drew closer.

"Shera?" Adora?"

Catra stopped at the mural.

Yup, that's clearly her.

"Shera!" Catra shouted, her tail flicking in excitement as the wall lit up, again the familiar figure, the woman she'd been thinking about since she came here the first time, appeared before her.

"Shera," Adora intoned, her body still poised in the same regal stand. She opened her eyes, and immediately changed.

"Shera! Your back! I…I didn't think, I didn't know if you'd come!"

Catra nearly laughed, giddy with the joy of seeing Adora's face go from placid to excited. No longer an image of stoic heroism but an actual person.

"Of course I came back silly!"

Adora smiled, a radiant wonderful smile, her image steadier now then it was before.

"What is you need Shera?"

“Please, call me Catra.”

“Catra,” Adora whispered in awe. The magicat’s heart skipped a beat hearing her name on Adora’s lips. Something caught her eye,

“Your….wrist,” she pointed to the little light flickering intermittently out of sync with the rest of Adora’s image. The Shera of old raised her arm quizzically before her.

“What is it?”

“I….” Catra held up her own opposite arm, “I have the same one. I thought it was a birthmark but now I’m not so sure.”

Adora stared at the identical marking on their wrist, they pulsed in time with magic. A warmth spread throughout Catra’s chest, she let out a shuddering breath.

“Adora, I need you to tell me everything. I need you to teach me how to be Shera.”

Chapter End Notes

> Had tons of fun writing this second chapter! Catra's Shera design based off Mickey Quinn's storyboards, but with red/white color scheme rather than Adora's gold/white.

A Severance of Soul Mates

Chapter Summary

Catra makes some discoveries.

"Faster!" Adora dictated, Catra grit her teeth, running towards the wall and jumped, managed to hit with her feet first, using the pressure to pounce off, back to the ground towards the target, she swung the sword, her cape whooshing behind her. She struck,

"Fuck!" The hologram slid out of reach at the last moment.

"H…how many of these did you say Prime had?" Catra wiped her sweaty brow with the back of her hand.

"Hundreds, thousands, too many to count."

"That's helpful," Catra huffed, tossing her longer hair over her shoulder. She fixed her fingers tighter around the sword and bit her lip.

"Ready? Again. Make sure you're working with the sword, not against it," Adora instructed.

That's what I've been doing for months!

Catra rushed forward towards the clone, this time trying to swipe under it, below the knees. It flickered and toppled. She pounced, driving the point of the blade downward and grinned, watching it tremor and fade out completely. Her ears swept back, she turned, another clone rushed at her, Catra dodged, turned, bringing the sword across to aim at it's torso. It too, flickered it's sickly green light and turned red, fading completely. Another rounded on her,

"Shit, how many of these are there?!"

“You just asked that!” Adora chided. There was no time for a smark rebuke. This next clone raised it’s clawed hand, snarling at her,

“You will be cleansed in Prime’s glory! All will burn in eternal fire!”

“Not if I have anything to say about it!” Catra grinned, reaching out and grabbing the clone’s wrist. Sharp claws clamored for her face,

“I’ve got those too you know,” *and they’re even stronger in Shera form!* She unleashed the tiny knives at the end of her fingers and drove them across the clone’s rage full face. It shrieked, stumbling backward. She released her hold, than flipped the sword, letting the pommel of the blade hit it in the stomach. The clone doubled over, and Catra pulled back just in time to meet yet another clone head on. It hissed at her with pointed teeth, no different from Hordak’s tantrums.

“You took all these,” she dodged again, tail just barely missing the grab of the clone, “all of these by yourself?!” For all of Adora’s story about her discovery of the sword, her rise to power and prominence as Shera and her subsequent fight with Horde Prime in the Heart of Etheria, it seemed that she had done the bulk of the fighting and suffering herself-rather than rely on the princess or Queen Angella for help.

“Catra concentrate!”

“I am consentrai…” an odd fuzzy sensation rippled through her, making her stomach churn. A holographic “X” on the front of her armor glowed.

“Damn it!” She sheathed the sword, frowning, watching the rest of the clones disappear. Only Adora stood before her, in her own Shera form as she always was, her eyes large and hopeful.

“You’re doing great.”

“No, I’m failing at this. I can’t even beat a simulation,” Catra growled, clenching her fists. She scowled at the warrior woman before her.

“I know it’s hard, I went through it myself. But you can do it. You can change the sword into anything you want, remember?”

Catra nodded, trying to catch her breath. She’d been training with Adora for months now, trying to learn how to embody the legendary warrior, champion of Etheria. All while helping Glimmer and Bow try to rekindle the Princess Alliance and stay under the radar of the Horde. Somethings must have gotten lost along the way during one of their many training sessions.

“Anything I want?”

“I used to turn it into a spear, a whip, one time a staff, anything really.”

A whip huh?

“Alright princess,” Catra smirked, “let’s go again then.”

Adora’s brow furrowed in concern, a look Catra had come to love and loath all in one.

“Are you sure you don’t want to take a break?”

“From all you’ve told me about him, Horde Prime doesn’t seem like one to take any breaks.”

“Very true,” Adora smiled sheepishly. She looked to Catra who nodded, her stomach going in knots just like it always did in these small periods of silence between them. When their eyes met, when both her little mark and Adora’s glowed and pulsed in unison, as though they were one heartbeat. Heat rose in Catra’s belly, all the way up to her face.

Don’t think about that right now!

“Okay, I’m ready.”

Adora grinned, cocky and adorable, Catra turned to face the new holograms with renewed determination, hefting the sword in her grip.

“Aaaarrrghhh!!!”

They advanced as one, Catra parried backward, summoning her magic, Shera’s magic, willing the sword to transform. It thrummed in her hold, glowing more intently, shining with golden light. The clones droned closer, their cries nearly muted by the buzzing in Catra’s ears with the sword's transformation. It shifted, changing in her hold, slimmer, even lighter. No longer so broad or heavy but slick and malleable. The light faded.

“It worked!”

Giddy, Catra cracked the ruby red whip, it’s long length snaking through mid air and snapping at the nearest clone. It was down in an instant, though even she couldn’t make out the exact place of the blow. She flung the whip to her right, taking out two more clones. This way, she kept them out of arm's reach from her. Catra’s chest radiated with adrenaline, dancing around the hall, watching the tip of the whip closely, trying to aim more and more precisely. For each clone the whip took out, three more appeared, their empty green eyes staring at her, fists and claws trying to knock her down. The whip cracked again as she spun and vaulted over the first line of them. Mid-air Catra twirled, bringing the whip down over their heads.

“Cast out the shadows! Cast out the shadows! Cast out the shadows!”

They continued to chant despite the falls in their ranks.

“Won’t they shut up?!”

Catra ran at them again, hissing and baring her own fangs as they challenged her. She cracked the whip once more, this time aiming

to coil it around the arm of the closest clone. She tugged it forward, bringing him close enough to get her claws in it's chest. Her fingers passed through it, it's green light shimmering each time she moved. It blinked red, and faded.

I can't touch them, but…could I touch Adora? Maybe? No time for that now! Go!

Catra lashed out, punching another clone in the side, and ducked before one more could make a blow at her head. It's fist missed, flying into its brother. Both turned red and faded away. She skirted out the way, ran towards the far wall, leapt off again and through the hologram of three more, holding her breath at the terrible fuzzy sensation going through her body.

Worse than Sparkle's teleports!

Her vision filled with red light then the clones disappeared again and Adora's beaming face remained, clapping.

"Catra, that was wonderful!"

Adora's praise alighted her heart. She glanced down at the whip in her grasp.

"Can I keep it like this?"

"Of course you can!"

Catra coiled the length of it, and tucked it to her belt with satisfaction, walking up to Adora, a light snarky smile playing on her face. She always smiled with Adora, no matter how grueling the exercise or long the expositions Adora gave as her time as Shera. They regarded each other again in that weighted stillness, Adora's bright blue eyes shimmering, looking into Catra's own. She bit her tongue, tail flicking in excitement.

Catra retracted her claws, raising one hand up to Adora, fingers eager to caress that mighty face, so powerful in her Shera form and yet holding a secret softness Catra dared to touch.

What did she look like…when she wasn't Shera?

Her wrist pulsed with that light as she drew closer, willing herself to feel something, anything of Adora. The warrior woman gazed back at her, eyes somber and sad. All wit and bravado deflated, as her fingers passed through Adora's cheek, tingling her fingertips. The light around her cheek where Catra attempted to touch her fizzled and faded, then reappeared. Adora closed her eyes, head listening to that side, trying to lean into the ghost of Catra's touch.

"I….I can't touch you," Catra stated dumbly. Adora only shook her head.

So close, so explicitly close and yet… yet the warmth of Adora's skin was not to be. It was in another time and place, a time and place Catra had missed, had only heard stories of.

"W…were you alone?"

The question came from some unknown place inside her, yet she knew it needed to be asked. Not that she wanted to know the answer, but this distance between them compelled her. Adora opened her eyes again.

"Yes," she breathed. Catra's heart hitched. She kept her hand as close as she could against the hologram's light.

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be, it was my destiny to go to the Heart of Etheria. It might have even been my destiny to fail, I don't know. But I was able to hold Prime off, keep him from destroying everything, insure that a new Shera would rise to do what I couldn't."

Catra swallowed the lump in her throat roughly, trying again to reach out and touch Adora. Again her image only flickered around the cheek, passing through nothing at all.

So that is my destiny?

“Catra,” Adora murmured, her sad eyes a prayer, “I broke the Sword of Protection when I had it. I severed my ties to the First Ones because I would not sacrifice myself for them. I chose to sacrifice myself for my friends and for Etheria. You do not need to do anything you don’t want to do.”

“But,” Catra tried to suss out, “you’re here. In a First Ones temple, you can’t leave it can you. Can you?”

A small flicker of hope came to her chest at the thought.

I could get Adora out of here, bring her to Brightmoon, to Sparkles and Arrow Boy and Angella. She could tell us all what to do. She wouldn't have to be so lonely here.

Inches from her face, Adora’s lips lifted in a little smile.

“I wish I could Catra, but…after…after the Heart…I…I don’t know exactly what happened. My body was destroyed,” her voice caught in her chest and for a moment Catra watched her gaze go far beyond their moment, to somewhere far away and far off. Her radiant light flickered, thinning.

“Adora? Stay with me okay?”

She shifted back, rematerializing again, finding Catra’s gaze. The magicat winced as Adora’s own hands impulsively moved to touch her shoulder. Instead only that dizzying magic, her hands fading in and out.

“I…I don’t know what happened exactly. But the sorceresses and sorcerers of Mystacor, along with the princesses somehow managed to tie my essence, this part of me, to the tech of the First Ones to make this Hologram.”

“How?”

If I know how….we could get that Entrapta princess to do something with it. Improve it, make it so she could go anywhere she wanted. Make it so we could touch.

"I don't know how they did it. They weren't around for me to ask and I can only access my memories of my time as Shera and…."

"Hey, it's okay," Catra forced herself to be calm, even as the little tiny flecks of blue tears gathered in Adora's eyes. She wished she could wipe them away, with all her heart she wished it.

What good is Shera if I can't help Adora? Seems like being Shera's caused nothing but suffering for her.

"Adora, you're such an idiot."

The woman's brows furrowed, she jerked away.

"I'm just kidding silly, I mean that in a good way. You're an idiot because I'm going to help you. I'll, how did you say it, fulfill my destiny as Shera?"

With so many months away from the Horde, she'd exhausted any other options at this point. Burned too many bridges to refuse.

"You don't have to Catra!" Adora's tone changed to urgency, she reached for her again, but again the pit of air was the only thing she could grasp. "I made my choice, like the Shera before me, I broke the sword so you wouldn't have to do what I did. So you wouldn't have to go through it. Destiny is a lie Catra."

It was the magicat's turn to step back, looking over the hologram of the woman before her. The warrior woman, Shera, Adora, who's path she believed she was doomed to follow.

"I want to help you, Adora. I want to get you out of here. I don't want Etheria to be destroyed. I have friends here…I have you."

"I'm useless as I am," Adora cried. "A stupid hologram, I can hardly move, I can't even touch the woman I lo…" her voice faded off.

Catra took a shaking breath, tail lashing behind her. She glanced at their matching marks.

“Adora you never told me what these markings on our wrists are,” Catra held up her arm. Adora looked to her own.

“I…don’t know, I’ve always had it but it never glowed like this before now…before I met you.”

Catra nodded, trying not to betray her frustration.

“Well, there was that one time,” Adora recalled absently. Catra signed, rolling her eyes. Wishing she could hit the woman good-naturedly on the back and make fun of her. The fact that she couldn’t made her chest sting.

“What time Adora?!”

“I wasn’t there, wherever it started but…when Horde Prime came the first time…he came through a portal right?”

“So you’ve told me.”

Adora nodded to herself, eyes shifting left and right, trying to recall her memory.

“Well, they tried to stop the portal.”

They?

“Someone pulled a switch on the portal that was setup, trying to close it to stop the Horde-so we think. But it didn’t work, I don’t know…there was just light all around, white light and everything was perfect…and then it wasn’t.”

Catra dragged her hands down her face,

“Adora, you're not making any sense.”

But Adora didn’t seem to be paying any attention. Her holographic image spluttered, rapidly phasing in and out and in and out, her face revealing more pain each time it came into view.

"Adora!" Catra tried to reach out, even knowing it was futile. "Adora! Please! Stay with me! Adora!"

"It was wrong, so, so wrong, nothing was in order, nothing is in order now! Catra…he's coming….I can't…I…it's all messed up. It's not perfect, it…it…it…it"

Adora's image went out, back in, then out, face frozen in panic. Catra waved her hands frantically,

"Adora! Come back! Adora!"

"Unauthorized presence detected, unauthorized presence detected!"

The room turned red, the walls, floor, ceiling, the entirety of the temple glowing ominous. Catra reached for her whip, watching in horror as Adora's last freeze frame dissolved, just like the clones.

What?! No, no, no, please come back! No! No!

She looked down sharply, the usual light around her mark that beat when Adora was around now went dormant, turning again to brown flesh.

"Unauthorized presence detected, unauthorized presence detected!"

No!

Catra looked wildly around, trying to staunch her frenzy.

It must be coming from somewhere outside!

She waited again for Adora's image to return even as the walls of the Crystal Castle seemed to shift, moving in closer, suffocating.

"I'll be back, I promise."

Catra fled, heart wrenching in her chest as she did so. She dropped to all fours, bolting as fast as she could down the long

hallway,

“Eternia!”

The doors slid open. Catra slid out, air rushing behind her, she let out a gasp as she skidded to a halt among leaves and dirt. All around her the trees shifted, the ground under her undulated. She watched in abject terror as the landscape itself seemed to change before her very eyes, obscuring any sign of the Crystal Castle.

“Adora!!!!”

A whirring sound above, the smell of smoke.

As if this day couldn’t get any worse.

“Down there!”

She yelped, narrowly missing the red heated laser as it burned its way through the forest.

Have to get back to Brightmoon, warn Glimmer and Bow.

Catra vaulted over a large root, hiding in the wedge of the root flare,

“She’s close!”

She sniffed, then winced hearing troops jump from the skiff and landed not far off.

Summoning her confidence, imagining Adora’s approving face, Catra stepped from her hiding place.

“Oh no,” she cooed, standing before the array of soldiers. “You found me, whatever shall I do?”

They bared their batons, three of them carried guns, and the largest one among them squared their stance. Catra charged forward, whip snapping, darting like a snake in the sky. One of them rushed at her head on, she swerved to the left arching her

whip in a single stroke. It cracked off the back of the soldier, but they came forward anyway, driving their baton forward. Catra jumped up to a tree branch.

“Sword!”

The whip glowed red, then transformed into a blade.

That’s more like it. Follow Adora’s instructions. Magic is about intention. It’s…

The blast from a gun illuminated rocket fast past her. It grazed her hip and she winced in anticipation of the pain, only to feel a dull throb.

Interesting….

Catra took aim, jumping down from her perch, onto the head of the Horde soldier. She brought down the sword against them, battering them. Unlike the training exercises they did not face out and disappear. Instead Catra bashed their temple with the pommel of the sword and dove off of them as they stumbled to the ground. Magic glowing, she aimed for the next two who ran at her simultaneously.

“You can do it,” Adora’s voice echoed in her mind. She smiled, taking them out with a slice of her sword and swipe of her claws.

Catra fought with berserk energy, allowing the magic of Shera to take hold of her, alternating between the whip and the sword where it fit. Evading blows and healing anytime one of them landed a shot or a hit, which was rare. Breathless, she stood over the body of the latest soldier.

“Go back to the Fright Zone,” Catra ordered the last largest foe, covered head to tail in armor. “Tell them Shera is back so they better stop this war and get ready for what’s coming.”

“Uhhh,”

Hissing, Catra lashed her whip again, it bound the soldier, large as they were in it's red coils. She marched up to them, claws out, snarling.

"Go back," she seethed, "and tell them Shera is back."

Losing patience, she tore the helmet upward in a single yank. It came loose instantly, toppling to the ground and….

"Scorpia?!"

Catra starred dumbfounded. The large woman's eyes rounder than dinner plates, blinked up at her, cocking her head to the side.

"W…wild cat?!"

Catra instantly closed her eyes, transforming back to her normal self, hoping the scorpion woman had been too dazed and confused to realize.

"Catra?! I…it's you!"

Catra relinquished the whip, rolling it up furiously as not to look at her old acquaintance.

"We found you!" Scorpia all but sang, standing and removing her armor. "Oh Catra! I thought you were….I didn't know what happened!"

"Scorpia," Catra finally brought herself to look at the scorpion woman. She approached slowly, arms out in a gesture she hoped was non confrontational.

This is really not the time or place for this freakout!

"Catra, we thought you were dead! Well, I didn't think you were dead Kyle definitely did. What does he know, am I right? Everyone else was pretty sure you were alive but we couldn't be totally sure and…"

“Scorpia!”

Catra seized the woman by her shoulders, leaning close, trying to catch her breath.

“Scorpia, listen to me!” Catra pantted, suddenly out of breath and exhausted. “I know I haven’t always been nice to you, I know I haven’t been the friend you deserve,” she forced herself to meet those kind dark, trusting eyes. “I promise if we make it out of this I’ll be better, but right now we are in very real…”

The words died in her throat.

An unmistakable tract of raised, red, blistering skin scarred it’s way from the base of Scorpia’s neck down her inner arm to a crack in her exoskeleton. Any hope of concealing her Shera form was lost, Catra’s eyes began to glow blazing red with magic, with wrath.

“What. Did. She. Do?”

Scorpia’s mouth fell open once more as Catra transformed again, this time up close. She stood before Scorpia, rivaling her in height, whip already out, her cape billowing behind her.

“Catra…”

“What did she do to you Scorpia?” She whispered dangerously.

“I…n…nothing,” the woman rushed to explain, looking Catra over with shock and disbelief. “She…She wanted to know where you were, I told her…H..Hordak had assigned you additional…objects… objectives! Th..that’s why it was taking you so long,” the woman laughed uncomfortably, “of course all she had to do was ask Hordak himself and when she found out that wasn’t true, ooohhh she was not happy with me!” Scorpia ended on a sing song note.

Catra curled her fists, claws threatening to cut her palms.

“New plan,” she looked off in the distance at the hovering skiff, then back to Scorpia’s sweet face, the gnarled mark angrily pulling at soft flesh.

“We’re going back to the Fright Zone. Now.”

“You’re actually insane Horde Scum, you know that right?”

Catra held the communicator close, trying to see Glimmer’s disapproving face through the on coming smog of the Fright Zone.

“Please, Glimmer just hear me out…”

“Oh NOW you use my name, when you want something from me.”

“This isn’t about me, I need you to go to Dryll and ask Entrapta about First One’s tech and tying souls to it, and ask your mom, er…the queen about what they did with Shera when she…” Catra pinched her eyes closed, the image of Adora’s pained face making her throat thick. “When she died.”

“Catra, why do you need to know all this?!”

“Glimmer, do this for me, and…and I’ll let you kick some Horde butt.”

“How come you only use my real name when you want something from me?”

“Glimmer please…!”

The princess raised her brows, trying to hide a smile.

“You’re saying Glimmer please a lot, which means you’re desperate which means I can use this as leverage against you later.”

"Please, just ask Entrapta and your mom about tech and magic binding souls, then teleport yourself and Arrow Bow to the transit bay of the Fright Zone. Can you do that?"

"Alright, I'll bring you the intell when I save your ass."

Catra shook her head, but conceited.

I can do this. I'll save Adora…I'll make Shadow Weaver pay… somehow rally them against Prime…I can do this. I'm Shera. Shadow Weaver was wrong about you. You're not a failure. Hordak was wrong, you're not a worthless cadet. Think of everything Adora said. How she's trained you. How she's proud of you.

"Uh Catra, we…were approaching the transport bay. What do you want to do?"

Sure enough, the noxious fumes of metal and fuel penetrated the air as they touched down. Catra took a deep breath, flexing her claws.

"Just land us as close as you can, stick close to me, I'll take care of the rest."

Scorpia gave her a wary look, but nodded, beginning to slower the skiff.

Trusting as ever….she really needs to get better at that, she's going to get herself hurt.

They touched down in relative anonymity, Catra slipping into one of the spare Horde soldier uniforms, standing beside Scorpia as she reported back from her mission.

"There was no sign of her?"

"Nope, nada, zero, zilch, hahaha sorry to say. No reports."

"Debrief with your squad, then file your report."

Scorpia gave a half-hearted salute, gesturing for Catra to follow.

Some things never change, she thought of the endless hierarchy of the Horde, the rigid systems of soliderhood. She walked abreast of Scorpia as they made their way through the transport bay, into the cavernous metal halls of the Fright Zone. She sniffed, ears twitching, tail on high alert.

The Black Garnet Chamber shouldn't be far. Down four stairs, to the left, make a right at the forge, then across the gangway and down two more flights of stairs. Fourth door on the left.

"Uhh, Wild Cat? Are…are you sure we should be going this way, the barracks are down there," Scorpia gestured. Catra's eyes darted,

Lonnie's probably down there…Kyle and Rogelio too. If they saw me…. she could hear Lonnie's accusations already. She sniffed again.

No sign of them..

"No, we're on track."

The crossed the gangway, passing several cadets. She nodded to them lamely, not recognizing their faces or their scents.

Have I really been away that long?

"On..on track to…where? I…I need to file my report. It's..It's basic force captain duty you know? Or I guess maybe you don't know since you were never made Force Captain?"

Catra kept walking, her ears flicked back.

"S…Sorry, I mean, being Shera is better than any Force Captain right?"

Heat, hot metal, electricity, she sniffed again, jumping down the last flight of stairs. *Magic.* A tremor went down her spine, Catra

reached for the hilt of the sword, conveniently concealed in the baton's sheath.

"We're close. Stay close."

Scorpia gulped.

Fourth door on the right.

Catra stopped before the threshold of the closed green doors. How many times had she stood in this spot, eyes raw from crying, stomach heaving in anticipation of whatever punishment Shadow Weaver had in store?

Not this time. This time I'm the one who has the magic.

Adora's tales of the power and glory of the magic of Etheria, the magic of Shera, recanted with such reverence, spurred Catra on.

I can do this. I'm stronger than her now. Adora knows I am. She believes in me. She trained me well.

She pulled up the glove of her armor, heart falling at the little circular mark on her skin, unglowing, unfeeling, bare just as it had been before Adora.

No turning back now.

"So…uhh, how do we get in?"

Scorpia leaned over her shoulder, whispering urgently.

Catra punched the memorized code next to the door, she knew it well, from watching all those years, whether glancing up from the sorceresses restraints after dragging her out of the practice arena, or being carried in by medics.

She took a breath, unleashed the sword, the doors slid open.

"This, this is the Black Garnet Chamber isn't it?"

The rune stone itself loomed large, the source of the sorceress's power.

The source of all those wounds….all that fear. Breathe, in…out, just like Adora said. Adora, she better be okay.

The anxiety of it roiled within her, the sight of the stone, this dark room, all of it's wires and computers, the tables with scrolls tossed about.

She must've just left, she'll be back. She never leaves this shit-hole for long.

"A…are we looking for anything in particular or…?"

Catra slunk around the perimeter, eyeing the black garnet warily. Looking over scrolls, moving along the shadows, taking a wide cautious arch around the scrying fountain.

Comms are off, she thought, looking at the black screen above the desk. Only the single red light blinked intermittently. *She always had the comms off when we were in here.*

She bit her tongue, forcing down the bile in her throat. The memories that threatened to surface.

Adora, think of Adora. The soft white, pink and red lights making up her form. Those blue eyes, clear and sad yet tinged with infectious hope. That warm omnipresent magic that surrounds us whenever we're near. I hope she's okay, the Crystal Castle is always acting strange but…it's okay. After we're done here I'll go right back….Adora…

"What's this here?" Scorpia's claws clinked against something metal,

"Don't touch that!" Catra rushed over,

Some sort of handle thing? That wasn't there before.

"Just don't touch things in here okay? This place is filled with dark magic. It's not safe to…" Something caught her eyes, Catra's tail perked upward, ears twitching towards the doors before stooping downwards to the scroll scattered across the floor.

First One's writing? Since when can the old hag read first one's….."Shera?"

She picked it up, the aged paper unfurling. Scribbled dark ink messily configured peppered the entire roll in no order or sense. The normally straight edged lines and detailed shapes undulating and incomplete at points. Hard to discern.

"Shera, Princess of Power, throughout the millennia of Etheria. Crown princess of princesses. Known in the current age as Mara….and then Adora.

"Adora?! What, how?"

"Who's that," Scorpia tried to read over her shoulder. Catra shifted, eyes flicking towards the door again, she tried to pick up a scent, even a scant one.

Just fumes, fire, the usual.

"Scorpia!" She forced a deep breath, "Scorpia, just please, stand guard. Alert me if you hear anything okay?"

The scorpion woman obeyed, Catra eased a little sigh of relief, then turned back towards the page.

Horde Prime, Galactic Horde,

More lines of unreadable script. Catra's eyes jumped from symbol to symbol.

Adora? Adora?

"Come on, come on! You hag, why is this so out of order? Where are the missing marks?!" Her heart beat faster in her chest, claws

gripping the paper so tight it flaked, beginning to break.

…….if Shera can defeat Horde Prime, Heart of Etheria….another will finish if it is not done. Portal….will separate space from time… high risk…another if….Heart of Etheria…known as Adora….Shera is deeply connected to the magic of Etheria, connected body and soul….there will always be a Shera as long as Etheia needs one. Adora will be the last…unless…soul…souls…soul mate…souls tied. Soul marks…Shera…

"Soul mates….."

Catra winced, gripping her left arm. Her mark softly glowing, it's light duller than with Adora but there and pulsing lightly in and out and in and out.

"That's it…when Adora felt her mark the one time before we met….when the portal went off."

No…that's impossible. That's….that can't be…

"Catra,"

The sweetly saccharine voice threatened to turn her spine to liquid. She bit back the smallest, most shameful of whimpers. Hand slowly going for the sword.

"I always knew you'd come crawling back to the Horde." She could feel the sadistic smile on Shadow Weaver's face. Her limbs were led even as she forced herself to move, turning.

"Wild Cat," immobilized, red magic outlining her petrified form Scorpia's wide eyes pleaded softly.

"I knew you'd have to come groveling back sooner or later, you're not wanted anywhere else, you insolent child."

Catra's lips pulled into a cold snarl, ears pinning against her head. The sorceress stood before her, mask as unreadable as ever, her shadows looming, snaking around her robes.

“You hurt Scorpia.”

“Scorpia deceived me and Lord Hordak. She needed to be punished.”

Catra forced herself to look beyond the foreboding woman, toward her friend who stood stiffly where she stood at the doorway. That long messy tract of ruined flesh glowing red with the rest of the sorceress's magic, but not so red as Scorpia’s tear streaked eyes. Catra’s heart cracked, unleashing fury.

A fervor of wrath washed over Catra, building up inside of her, fueling her magic. Red light, a brighter, cleaner red than any cast by the Black Garnet filled her form, and Catra felt herself transform. The sword instantly becoming the whip she willed it to be.

Shadow Weaver stepped backward, the white lenses of her mask growing large. Her shadows trembled but for a moment, shriveling and shrinking.

That’s right you old crone. Not so powerful anymore are you?

“You’re never going to hurt Scorpia again. Not her, not me, not anyone!” She cracked her whip as Shadow Weaver recovered from her shock, daring to step closer. The whip swiveled with its own magical light.

“Unanticipated I admit,” Shadow Weaver drolled, “why the deep magic of Etheria would want anything with a pathetic worthless creature like yourself is beyond my knowledge.” Her shadows began to grow, spreading across the floor and up the walls, “but no matter. No fancy sword, no change of dress will change the truth.”

No, no, no, don’t panic Catra, you’re not a little kitten anymore. You can protect yourself. Protect Scorpia. You’re Shera damn it! Shera!

She sprang away from the nearest tendril of shadow, crawling across the floor, the whip cracked, it shrank back but an inch. Catra kept her eyes trained on the sorceress.

Please sound daring.

"And what truth is that Shadow Weaver?"

The sorceress floated closer, robes rippling. The air around them, already thick with smoke now even heavier. No windows, no lights but the glowing red.

"The truth, that you are a meaningless, destitute little urchin as you always have been. A mistake, an outcast, good for nothing. I should have put you down like the best you are!"

"W…wild Cat….y…you're not…d…don't l..listen," Scorpia struggled to speak, sweat beginning to bead on her brow. The large woman groaned, trembling. The red electrifying magic around her body brightened, flaring, Scorpia screamed, falling to the ground, curling in on herself. It wouldn't do Scorpia any good, just like it never did Catra any good.

"Let her go. Now."

"Oh Catra, you're in no position to give any orders," the shadows crawled closer, coming from all sides.

Adora….Adora please…if only Adora was here….

The mark on Catra's wrist pulsed. It's light, encouraging her.

"I'm Shera now.* I can give any orders I want. Let. Scorpia. Go."

The scorpion woman groaned, then coughed, her pinchers trying to grasp at the metal floor even as the magic wracked her.

You can do this. Adora knows you can do this. You have the magic of Etheria within you. Use it.

“She’s worse than you are! Cowering. Pathetic.”

Shadow Weaver drifted closer, the shadows finally closing in.around them. One long robbed hand reaching out…

“For the honor of GraySkull!”

Catra lifted her whip, and lunged.

Shadows Weaving

Chapter Summary

> Catra faces off against Shadow Weaver. Glimmer provides some intel. Scorpia discovers her power.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shadow Weaver was nothing if not horrifying. A terror no amount of magic could dampen. Despite her Shera form, despite her weapon and claws and skill, Catra's heart pounded against her sternum, trying to break free. Another shadow slithered wickedly to her left, she flashed her whip, the bright red magic slashing through the dark. It cracked and the shadowy tendril dissipated.

"You may be Shera," the sorceress taunted from her place next to the Black Garnet, her robes dancing with the electric lightning. "But that changes nothing, you pathetic wretch!"

Don't let her words make you weak. She can't hurt me anymore she can't…

Catra yelped, darting out of the clutches from another wave of shadows clamoring for her. She jumped onto the ruin stone, her claws clamoring into the smooth facade. Red Sparks alighted at the contact, electrifying light fully charged, searing through her body. Blasting through her veins and setting her hair on edge. Her whole form trembled. Her Shera form prevented her from gross physical injury, but it did nothing to dull physical pain.

"Please, make it stop! I'm sorry, I'm sorry!"

"Get up, you worthless little monster!"

"Aaaarrrgh!" Catra's claws released on instinct. She fell, twisted, landed on her feet. Shadow Weaver's raucous laugh cutting across

her skin worse than the magic of the stone.

“Let Scorpia go! Now!”

She cracked her whip at another shadow trying to slither between her legs. It sparked when she hit it and withdrew several feet.

“Are you really going to drag this out?”

Catra grit her teeth, whittling the whip around her body at the onslaught of more dark tendrils. They attempted to consume her, blocking her vision of Scorpia and the Sorceress. A howling hiss raging through her head.

Look out, get away! Hide! Hide!

The child in her mind fretted. The whip’s end spun, crackling hot energy around her. Tearing little holes through the fog of black.

“You are nothing to me, you will never be anything to anyone. You are weak and cowardly!”

Shadow Weaver’s voice filled the maelstrom of shadow.

You’re Shera now, Catra recalled Adora’s words to her in the castle. *It is up to you to decide what you want to do. Whatever that is, I’ll do my best to train you.*

Adora’s kind sunshine smile, how she wished she could see it in life.

“Let Scorpia go! Now! She has nothing to do with this!”

Catra’s magic exploded, the whip wrecking fury upon the shadows in rapid flourishes, energy sparking, driving the shadows back. She tried to catch her breath, sweat beginning to bead along her forehead. This room was always so tiny, so cramped and claustrophobic.

“W…wold…c…cat.”

Scorpia pleaded from her place on the floor, her claws trembling. Tears ran down her eyes. Catra's fists balled in rage, turning to Shadow Weaver, staring through those placid whites of her mask. The sorceress gestured wildly, the reems of her robes stretching outward from her arms towards Catra. She sprang out of the way, onto one of the massive wires hooked up to the ruin stone. This time, careful not to slip and touch the garnet itself.

"Adora," Catra blurted, another shadowy wraith dove at her from above. She vaulted, swinging her whip down mid-air, aiming for Shadow Weaver's head. The sorceress slipped out of the way, so fast she could barely see it, her masked face jerking upward in recognition.

Catra gasped, coming to land beside Scorpia. She reached out tentatively placing a hand on the woman's shoulder. Catra winced at the electrifying sparks blistering into her skin.

"I…I'll get you out of here," she whispered through grit teeth, "just hang in there."

Scorpia opened one eye, meeting Catra's but nodded. The magicat straightened, withdrawing her hand to turn the whip back into a sword and face Shadow Weaver once more.

"You know that name don't you?"

"I don't know what you're talking about," the sorceress hissed. Her shadows weaving and drifting like cobras in the air, ready to strike. Catra glanced at the scroll, still where she'd dropped it.

The portal,

Catra's eyes shifted, past the sorceress, to the strange, seemingly out of place lever sticking awkwardly out of the floor.

The switch!

The realization crashed upon her at once. She snarled, tail lashing behind her and jumped again, sword slashing at the shadows. It's

blade hit something solid through the shadows.

“Aaaaahhh!!!”

Catra got her footing, standing behind the sorceress, who grabbed at her shoulder.

“You pulled the switch!” Catra evaded another assault of shadows, slashing at them mercilessly with her sword. “You…k…knew Horde Prime was coming!”

“Argh!” Shadow Weaver spun, her finger starting to draw a sigil in the air. Catra brought her sword down across it, flashing red magic severing it to pieces.

“You knew Adora! Knew she was destined to stop him!”

Adora’s beautiful, face shimmered in Catra’s mind. Her determination and her grit, her sadness and the magic she held in her heart. Catra’s birthmark, no…soulmark pulsed with life.

“You….urgh!” A shadow seared across her side, Catra hit it on it’s second pass towards her, thrusting the blade out and stabbing it through. The shadow fizzled then faded.

“You knew we were connected somehow and you pulled the switch to activate the portal so we’d never meet…”

“Yes,” Adora had said, when she asked if the woman had been alone at the Heart of Etheria.

“I failed.”

“You!” Shadow Weaver gasped, “you know not of what you speak!”

Shadows leapt for her again, Catra dodged, then jumped, spun, stood upon the controls and vaulted over, back again at the sorceress, sword in hand. She slashed it down, cutting through robes. Shadow Weaver shrieked, stumbled, and caught herself.

“You made sure we’d never meet. You wanted her to fail! You evil, selfish, piece of…”

Catra’s body spasmed, she dropped the sword, her entire form going rigid. Red lightning gripped her in its clutch.

“Aaaarrggh!”

No, no this can’t be happening! No please!

She convulsed with the power of the Black Garnet coursing through her body. Her vision spotting, Scorpia’s sobs barely audible over her own anguished cries.

“I knew you were a meddling brat,” Shadow Weaver stood before the Black Garnet, one gray clawed hand on the rune stone, the other outstretched, weaving the magic that stabbed through her. “You do not understand the first thing about Shera, or soulmates or Adora!”

“I…..kn…know enough,” Catra gasped out, her feet levitated off the floor, a dark purple shadowy cloud lifting her up, over Shadow Weaver even as the red lightning pierced her.

“Adora is dead, Horde Prime may have been thwarted once but he shall return, and with you as Shera,” she laughed deep and cackling, “well, if you are Etheria’s champion then I weep for Etheria!”

The magic tore through her body, Catra squirmed, curling in on herself, the old tried and true way of getting through the pain.

You have to fight it!

Adora is counting on you, Scorpia is counting on you!

Fight it! You’re Shera! Adora believes in you!

But the agony riddled through her, making her breath short and heart hammer, her joints creak and crack.

“Adora was supposed to be the last,” Shadow Weaver continued, “but Etheria must have a Shera and so you found your way to the sword after deserting. No matter, you’ve been a pain in my side long enough and now that you’re Shera it’s time I put you down for good.”

The cloud of magic fully enveloped her, dark red lightning cracking across her back. The shadows seeped into her ears, crawled upward into her nose.

“AAAAAARRRHHHHH!!!”

Catra shrieked, the shadows slithering into her mouth, down her throat. The lightning burning, burning burning her skin, singing her fur.

Don’t hurt me, I promise I’ll be good just let me go!

You’re Shera now Catra.

Adora’s smile, her light.

It’s your choice.

Shera, Princess of Power!

You are the most powerful princess, Adora had told her. A being of the deepest magic of Etheria.

Adora…..

Adora help me….Adora!

Catra’s soul-mark pulsed, the light urgently pulsing warm against her skin. She closed her eyes against the oppressive shadows,

A creature of the deepest magic of Etheria

Adora…!

“AAAaaaaarrrghhh!”

Catra's chest heaved with heated magic, the sword instantly finding its way into her grip, through the cloud of shadows. Light burst forth from the stone within it, dispelling the shadows. Catra's body thrummed with power, with magic, from that place deep within her, the place joined inexplicably with Adora. The shadows shrieked, then obliterated in the face of her magic. The simmering burning dark red streaks of lightning instantly changed, turning to a bright brilliant red, sparkling and redirected outward, blasting through glass and metal, the Black Garnet vibrating with life the wires and shackles around it crumbling. Catra sailed forward, leaveling the sword over her head and brought the blade downward,

Crrraaaack!

Shadow Weaver let out a wail, cowering to the ground. Her mask falling in shards to the floor. The little piece of the Black Garnet inbedded in her mask, in pieces.

"You….w…will never lay a…hand on anyone again,"

Catra lifted the point of the sword to the sorceress's chin, forcing her true face upward.

"Look at me,"

The gnarled, scarred splitface of her tormentor glared.

"You hold no power over me, over the Black Garnet or the Horde any longer. I AM Shera, and I am going to save Adora and vanquish this Horde Prime."

Shadow Weaver's broken lips only smiled.

"Oh Catra, you were always one for dramatics. You're a fool."

No anger, no flare of spite or need to rebuke came forth within her, only defiance, only determination.

"You're wrong,"

She let the outburst of magical energy fade slightly. Transforming back to her usual self, her body aching with bruises and throbbing with hurt but she steeled herself, smiling still. Catra crept closer, one hand cupping Shadow Weaver's leathery skin, she smoothed a piece of disheveled hair out of the woman's face and stroked her thumb along the uneven scar of her cheek.

This was the woman who raised me. Who never believed I was good enough. The woman responsible for Adora's death, who seperated us before we could ever meet.

"What are you g…going to do…do with her?"

Scorpia asked shyly, Catra's gaze did not wane from Shadow Weaver's green, loathing eyes. She sucked a deep breath, waiting for some petty remark, some need for further vengeance or violence, but none came.

Shit, maybe Shera is getting the best of me after all.

"She's powerless now, let her rot."

Catra sheathed the sword, turning her back on the one who'd tortured her all thsoe years.

"C'm on, we have to go meet Spark…Scorpia, were you doing?"

The scorpion woman knelt no longer by the door where she was trapped but, by the Black Garnet. One tip of her pincer grazing it's surface, a little spark of magic fizzled and cracked at the connection. Scorpia stood shakily, following Catra to the door.

"Well, uh, it's w…weird you see, when you went up into that cloud, I really thought you were a gonner! But then uhh you kinda exploded with magic and it was all like bbbbbsssshhh! And all the this red light, and well, I realized I could move again and I don't know why but I felt like I should touch the rune stone, so I did and wow, I tell you, I don't know what I was expecting but THAT was not it! I touched it and WHAM! Magic! I always knew I was a princess but I didn't realized the Black Garnet was waiting for ME

to come to IT! I thought it just didn't like me! Can stones not like people? Anyway I touched it and I was all red and glowy! But not in the ouchy way, more like in a WOW I FEEL SO POWERFUL way!"

Catra let Scorpia's rant distract her, having no need to speak to Shadow Weaver, or even glance over her shoulder for a last look. The doors slid shut and that was that.

"You…mean to tell me, that you're a princess and your rune stone is the Black Garnet?"

"Uhh, yeah I gue…"

"Intruders reported," Hordak's voice echoed throughout the hall, lights flashing red. "All soldiers seek them out immediately."

"Shit we gotta go!"

Catra tugged Scorpia along, up the stairs back across the gangway, thwarting any and all Horde soldiers in their way.

"We can jump on that skiff again," Catra shouted as they ran, "get Sparkles on the…"

Pink glittering magic burst into view, Glimmer's voice manifesting before her physical form.

"YOU. OWE. ME. BIG TIME!"

The princess of Brightmoon appeared before Catra, swinging her staff, knocking a soldier who attempted to attack from behind.

"Glimmer, can we talk about this later?" Bow pleaded at her arm.

"Hi everyone, I'm Scorpia, Catra's best…oh no you don't!"

Scorpia spun around, unleashing a zap of Black Garnet magic at four Horde soldiers. The screamed falling from the gang way, down into the vats below.

“Oh, shoot you know I didn’t realize there were molton tanks of lava down there…I’m really sorry.”

“Who’s this Catra? You’re new friend?”

“Yes, she is Sparkles. Can we save the meet and greet for later? Hordak knows we’re here!”

“No? Do they? I had NO IDEA!”

Glimmer punched at yet another solider.

“Glimmer can you teleport us out of here?!”

Catra starred over the princess’s shoulder at an oncoming squad.

“Oh so you just tell me to come here and then as soon as I start kicking some but you just want me to teleport you back?”

Glimmer rounded on the squad, taking out three of them with her staff and two with her fist.

“I’m not some flying horse Catra!”

Bow unleashed his arrow, shooting it downward, over the vats of lava to the tankers that divided the forge from the transport bay.

“Everyone hold on!”

He grabbed Glimmer to him, Catra dug her claws into the fabric of the princess’s cape, Scorpia wrapping her large arm over all three of them.

“You sure your trick arrow can hold us all?”

Dozens of Horde troops swarmed either side of the gangway, blasters and batons charged and ready.

“One way to find out!”

Bow jumped, Catra's stomach sloshed with nausea, Scorpia and Glimmer screamed in her ears as they swooped down the heated air of the forge lapped against them but not a hint of melted rock touched them.

They soared downward, crashing to the ground below. Catra righted herself quickly, pulling Glimmer up, then Scorpia, Bow fired another volley of arrows at their new attackers.

"Go for a skiff!"

Catra ordered over the blaring sirens.

"That one!" Bow fired another arrow, cutting away the ties that held the skiff to the ground. He jumped, Catra after him, landing on all fours and grabbing Glimmer by the collar, heaving her over the side.

"Scorpia!"

Catra's voice broke in a panic as the woman picked up her pace, knocking down five more soldiers in her wake with blasts of her magic.

"I can't jump!" She shouted, the ship ever rising.

"Yes you can!" Catra cried, "You can do it Scorpia! Come on! I got you!

Trust in yourself, Adora had said to her.

"Just…just trust in yourself! You can do it Scorp!"

With a grunt, Scorpia leapt, coming in for the skiff. She slammed downward, casting the thing to teeter, then right itself once more, up, up away from the lazer fire of robots and cannons.

"You did it Scorpia," Catra clasped her on the shoulder, pulling her to her feet, "I knew you could."

“Hang tight, we’re not out of the woods yet!” Bow instructed from his place at the steering helm.

“But for real,” Glimmer panted, “who is she?”

Catra managed an exhausted, adrenaline field grin,

“This, your royal Sparkle Butt, is Princess Scorpia.”

“Catra, really, you need to rest,” Glimmer set the tea tray down on Catra’s bedside table.

“I’ll rest later, I have to find Adora, I need to make sure she’s okay, tell her what I found.”

She paced back and forth, tail twitching behind her.

At least I can walk without stumbling finally. I’m fine, that means I’m better. It’s time to go.

They escaped the Horde’s soldiers and cannon fire, and their bots, made it safely back to Brightmoon, where Queen Agnella demanded an explanation from Glimmer not only about their newest recruit to the rebellion, and also princess of the Black Garnet, but about why they’d done to the Horde in the first place. Catra bemoaned an abbreviated version of her excursion. How Shadow Weaver was the one who opened the portal all those years ago, how Adora was destined to fail because the two of them were never able to meet. She kept the soul mates part private, her heart not ready to be so open with her love. Angella had many follow up questions as expected but had granted them time to heal and recuperate. All of Catra’s injuries taken as Shera had healed in the moment, but waking the next morning unable to hardly move without vomiting with the anguish confirmed that Shera’s magic didn’t go all the way to deal with underlying hurts and irradiated pain. Now, after what seemed like weeks she could finally walk, and pounce and climb again. It was time to find Adora.. It had been too long already.

Prime is coming. One asshole down, one more to go.

"Catra, are you even listening to me?"

Catra fixed the princess with a look but it was half-hearted, seeing the genuine concern in her eyes. She deflated,

"I know, you're right, okay? I know I need to rest, and I will. But I have to find Adora first, I…" Catra clenched her fists to keep her fingers from shaking.

"I need to make sure she's okay."

"Remember how you owe me one?" Glimmer challenged.

"Yes?"

"Then pay off your debt to me and get some rest, at least for another day."

Catra rolled her eyes, trying not to come off too aggressive.

"You know that's not what I meant. I just…I need to speak to her. Then I'll come back and we'll strategize, I'll go to all the meetings you want."

Glimmer arched a brow, hands on her hips.

"Really? ALL of them?"

"Most of them, just…I need to find Adora, I'll be back. I always come back Sparkles don't I?"

"Or I have to come save you and your insanely powerful princess friend you've been keeping secret."

Catra opened her mouth to retort,

"I asked Entrapta and my mother by the way, about binding souls to First Ones Tech."

Catra's ears perked, dashing closer to the princes so fast she nearly skidd on the clean polished floor. Glimmer giggled,

"They said it can be done, with enough magical energy and enough tech. It's possible, especially because they already did the hardest part before when she…when they initially captured her soul and bound it to the tech they had."

Catra listened, piecing it together slowly.

"I don't really know, she used a lot of fancy words, something about transferring a soul from being bound to First One's tech, to being bound to Etheria's magic instead so they could wander about freely."

Heat rose in Catra's chest,

Hope.

"So we could do that? With Adora's soul?"

"With enough magic and the right people to wield that magic, I think so? Don't hold me to anything okay? I might know magic, but mine's more the stabby stabby, beat you up kind," Glimmer made a gesture with her fists. "Less of the healing and tending benevolent souls kind."

Catra laughed, the heat in her chest welcome and giddy and light. Glimmer couldn't help but laugh at herself.

"Thanks Glim, I really do owe you," Catra smiled, lightly touching the princess's arm.

"You really do," Glimmer beamed. Her pink-purple eyes brimming with delight and a light heartedness between them Catra had yet to see before today.

"...and I will owe you! Riiight after I talk with Adora."

She made for the balcony, perching on the rail.

“There’s nothing I can do to make you stay and rest?”

“Make out with Arrow Boy for five minutes and let me make gross inappropriate comments at your expense the entire time?”

Glimmer’s face turned scarlet. Eyes bundling, cheeks puffing out in indignation.

“What? I know that’s what you were doing last night, that…” Catra turned over her shoulder to look Glimmer up and down,

“... and more, I can smell it on you. Oh and you can have those tea cakes by the way, I’m not going to eat them. Okay Sparkles, great chat, see you later!”

She scaled her way down the castle from the balcony, wincing at the bites of pain across her body and set out once more into the Whispering Woods for Adora.

“Adora!” Catra yelped, nearly tripping over yet another root. The chilly air of the Whispering Woods rushed through her hair, making snow stick to her skin.

“I…I was looking for the castle for so long but I couldn’t find it, it’s freezing out here!”

Adora’s holographic form, standing before her unaffected by the chill, laughed at her expense, another plume of snow beating against the magicat.

“I am tied to the First One’s tech, this beacon is part of that,” she gestured to the strange metal rod sticking out of the ground.

Huh, totally thought that was a dead tree, Catra decided not to confess aloud. She hugged her arms around herself, leaning closer to Adora’s image, knowing she would find no warmth there, however much she longed for it.

“Listen, Adora…I…I have a lot to tell you,” Catra began carefully. Adora’s eyes looked around at the falling snow, little specks of white dancing through the chilled air.

“Adora, are you even listening to me?” Catra blanched, after retelling everything about her encounter with Shadow Weaver.

Well, almost everything.

“It’s the solstice,” Adora quipped.

“Excuse me? ”Catra blinked, shivering at the wind.

“It’s the solstice,” Adora raised her arms, gently passing her hand through the millions of snowflakes as they fell. Catra watched her fingertips go through each and every one of them, her light fading in and out with each pass.

“So?”

Damn that gorgeous smile, it’s impossible to be that grumpy around her.

“So, it’s beautiful,” Adora gushed. Catra followed the woman’s gaze, over the evergreen branches laden with snow, the pure white fresh snow falling silently to the forest floor, blanketing it in a downy cover. The moons of Etheria cast light lilac purple through the woods, rippling with the wind. The snow spun and danced through the air, landing like little spirits on every surface. Catra smelled the crisp clean air, fresh and chilly.

“Yeah, I guess it is,” she finally sighed, allowing herself to enjoy the scene, or more accurately, enjoy Adora, enjoying the scene.

“We’re soulmates,” she whispered gently, looking from the snow, to Adora’s blue eyes.

“We’re….”

“Soulmates, I don’t know much about it…but Shadow Weaver made it so you could never leave, she wanted to make sure you failed..she…”

Adora stepped closer, her arms going on either side of Catra’s waste, hovering there.

“It won’t work Adora,” her voice trembled, she ached, though not from the cold. “You know it won’t work.”

The woman only smiled,looping her arms around Catra as close as could possibly be. Her magic vibrating and pulsing with energy so close Catra could feel it. Her heart thrummed in her chest, beating into her ears. Adora’s light that glowed around her, illuminated Catra too. She awkwardly lifted her own arms, on either side of Adora’s neck and clasped her hands together behind Adora’s head.

It’s so close, tears gathered in her eyes. All the adrenaline of her battle with Shadow Weaver was replaced with dread, all her certainty of being Adora’s soulmate replaced with an inescapable longing.

What does she feel like? Her skin, her eyes flicked downward, *her lips?*

Adora’s soulmark again glowed in rhythm with her own, their energy feeding off of one another. That deep place inside of Catra, the nucleus of her own soul, threatened to burst forth. The snow fell against her head, dusting her eyelashes, and passed through Adora’s form. In the glow of the moonlit dark, on this solstice day, Adora was her sun.

“I want to kiss you,” Adora whispered, tilting her head forward, ever closer.

Catra’s heart panged, she too edged closer, longing to press herself against Adora’s chest. The light of the hologram only fizzled when she did so, the image of Adora splintering for a moment. Tears rippled down Catra’s cheeks. Adora moved her

hands upward, as if to touch Catra's chin, as if to pull her close and seal their souls with a kiss. Catra's lips hovered inches from Adora's own but not yet touching. No breath escaped the other woman's mouth, no rush of heat, no smell beyond the pine and the snowflakes and the earth.

"I'm going to help you," Catra gasped, still so close to Adora. "I talked with Glimmer, there's a way to make it so you're not tied to the First Ones."

Adora's face lifted with optimism.

"Will I…will I be able to…touch you?" Adora murmured, almost embarrassed. A blush flitted to light on her cheeks.

"I…I don't know, I hope so. I'm working on it."

Catra sniffled, forcing this tumult of longing and sorrow downward, putting on a good snark instead.

"Careful what you wish for though princess, if I'm able to touch you, I don't think I'll ever stop."

She impulsively slid her hands downward, trying to feel Adora's hip, but her fingers met nothing but cold.

Adora gave a nervous little chuckle. She looked at Catra, the moonlight cutting across her face with grace, making her appear even more ethereal. Adora's fingertips hung right above Catra's cheek, their light brushing her skin.

"I…" the warrior woman, strong and impeccable as she was, fumbled with her words. "Catra," she breathed, those large clear blue eyes looked into the magicat's. Holding her there with reverence and adoration. It was Catra's turn to blush.

The wind howled, branches peeling from the trunk, the lightness of the sky changed.

Something's off,

Catra and Adora looked forward, following the wind. The clouds above become dark.

“Is that,” Catra squinted through the overcast sky.

Is that….a ship?

Adora’s holographic form bleeped out, then back in, but she remained close to Catra, one hand hovering just above her shoulder. It wasn’t the touch she needed at the moment, but it was as close as she was going to get. Catra watched Adora’s face turn stern, looking up to where something moved through the clouded sky. Her eyes narrowed, though currently in her Shera form, Catra watched Shera assume Adora’s face. Severe, angry, but with a flicker of fear behind her eyes.

“Is that….?”

Catra asked, though she knew the answer. Some part of her just wanted to hear Adora’s voice, needed to hear Adora confirm her worst fears.

The enormous ship broke through the gray, white and green, pointed and aimed straight to land.

Beside her Adora’s light flared, her eyes a blaze.

“It’s him.”

Chapter End Notes

> Four chapters down...one to go! Thank you for your patience. I tested positive for COVID on Monday and finally had the energy to post today. I'll be working on the fifth and final chapter as I feel up to it and have it posted as soon as it is ready. Thanks so much to everyone for all your support.
>
> Also I can't write fight scenes for the life of me. Hope you enjoy nonetheless!

The Heart

Chapter Summary

> Catra accepts the fail-safe and must not only return magic to Etheria, but save Adora as well.

"What," Catra swallowed, her ears perked forward to the thrum of the ship that descended, obscuring the pastel clouds in all its enormity.

"What…do I do? The Heart of Etheria, you said you held it inside you, right? How can I use it?"

Aodra's brow furrowed, her face drawn. Her arm reached outward, would have touched Catra's hand but only dissolved away. Catra's soul-mark glowed in time with Adora's.

"There's a fail-safe," Adora glanced down at her chest, Catra's keen eyes followed. She bit her tongue. "You can use it the way I couldn't, to stop the Heart of Etheria from activating. "I…I'm so,"

"Don't say it," Catra turned her back from the onslaught of Prime's ships, looking only to Adora. "Don't even say it. I'm Shera now, remember? I'll be fine, okay? Just tell me how I can get the fail-safe to the heart and disable it."

A sickly green flash split the sky. Catra's body shivered, the magic vibrating through her, called from deep within, as if summoned by

Etheria itself.

Guess it's time already.

Taking a deep breath, she let the magic fully transform her into Shera.

She opened her eyes, and gasped.

"What are those?" Catra balked at the strane columns of green light sent down from the ship, to the planet's surface. They split the trees with a sharp crack, one appeared, then disappeared, then another, another all in rapid succession. Her tail flicked behind her rapidly, ready.

"They're clones," Adora explained, her voice tight. "He has clones, countless ones. That's how he takes over."

The princess alliance…..Sparkles, Arrow Boy….Scorpia! They can't handle this! Speakrles only just got the rest of the Princess Alliance together and all they do is argue, they don't stand a chance against Prime.

Catra shoved that thought aside for the moment, *the best thing I can do for them is to get to the Heart.*

She pulled her whip from her belt, managing to put on a sure-fire grin over her shoulder at Adora.

"Catra," the woman's voice choked. Her image fizzled in and out with each beam of green light coming down from the ship.

"What is it, what's wrong?"

"It…it'll be dangerous for you," Adora repeated, only this time Catra could see her whole form shaking. "There's no…no guarantee you'll survive." Catra took a breath for a moment, allowing the thick dread to well within her stomach, doubt creeping in. Beams of green light shot into the Etherian forests, cutting across rivers. The magic within her stirred, discontent.

You're a failure, you will never be anything. Shadow Weaver's voice taunted.

I beat Shadow Weaver. I showed her who was boss, I can do the same with Prime. There's no way he'w worse than Hordak.

…and if…if Adora's right and I…don't make it, Catra's tail flicked back and forth. Fists clenched. She steeled herself, before turning to Adora once more.

"Even if I don't make it, maybe we can be..you know….really together after all?"

Is that the only way?

Adora’s hands made to go to her face but passed right through.

“Don’t say that!” Her soul mate cried, urgently, trying again to placate Catra. Her hands flitting about but they would not grace the magicat’s skin. No matter how many times she tried. “Don’t ever say that!”

Catra motioned to take Adora’s shoulders but her cupped palms only passed through the grainy hologram.

“Okay, fine, let’s just…let’s just do this. We’ll figure it out.”

Adora’s image faded in and out again, as the clones beamed down from Prime’s flagship, but the elder Shera spoke resolutely.

“You need to get to Arkseaa, that’s where you can absorb the power of the failsafe. Bow and his dad's, they'll know where it is.”

“Right,” Catra’s mind flew miles a minute, trying to strategize, tying to plan.

"The closer you get to the heart the more magical energy there will be. I'll be there," Adora held her hand just hovering over Catra's chest, she could almost imagine that warm smooth touch. So close, caressing over her skin. "I'll be there with you okay? If I can."

If you can?! No, no, no, there can't be an if! There's too many 'ifs!"

Catra looked into the woman's eyes, their soul-marks thrumming intime. She nodded.

"I know. We're going to fix this."

"Just, be careful," Adora's fingers curled as if to grasp Catra's front, as if to pull her close against her. But it was not to be. It never would.

Unless I can do this. Unless Shera can do this, Catra looked down at her clowning whip. Feeling it's magic pulse through her veins.

"See you at the heart?"

Catra hoped the slight crack in her voice was not heard. Adora nodded,

“I promise.”

“Promise.”

She held the image of Adora in her mind as she dashed on all fours quickly through the forest. Recalling the light and energy of her near-touch, it propelled her forward, sneaking past clones through a much more grim Etheria.

- – -

“Perfuma, Mermista and the others are already trying to fend off as many clones as they can,” Glimmer paced the council room, teleported around the council room in a flurry of pink sparkles that would’ve irritated Catra under any other circumstance if things were not more dire. Even Scorpia stood still, though her tail shook, ready to strike, on edge.

“Adora told me we need to get to a place called Arksia, that's where the failsafe for the heart is. You know about it right? George and Lance told you?”

“Arksia?” Scorpia wrung her claws together, periodically jolting with red electric energy, “where is that?”

Bow, busied his nervous hands with his data-pad.

"It's under the tunnels of Mysticore so…I probably can. But there are clones reigning down from the sky! We'll have to do it quickly and be stealthy about it."

His gaze slung to Glimmer who teleported agan and re-appeared across the room on top of the table in a string of curses.

"What? I'm the queen of stealth!"

"Haha," Scorpia's nervous laughter sounded, "If you're the queen of stealth then I'm a hermit crab."

Somehow, despite it all, Catra laughed, allowing some lightness to flood her scenes if only for a moment. A crash, and a cry from outside quickly killed it. Another reign of bots fired towards the palace walls no doubt. Every second or so another flash of pale green light swallowed the sky.

Another clone, another series of bots. More armies, maybe Prime himself is here. On Etheria? No, I'd sense it. He's probably still hiding up in his ship? Would I be able to sense him getting closer? There wasn't enough time, Adora…she couldn't tell me everything about the magic of Shera…just how to fight. I hope she's okay. What if Prime realizes that part of her is still here?! What if….

Catra flinched at Arrow Boy's touch, raising her whip.

"Ahh! Sorry, sorry, just…" he looked at her with sympathy. Maybe her facade was failing. "Sorry Catra, it's just…if we want to do this. We have to go now."

he nodded, taking a heavy breath, reaching up and squeezing his hand on her shoulder. Warm and generous and always helpful, even when he'd help capture her.

"You're right," she answered tightly, giving his hand one more squeeze, hoping the unspoken thank you was translated. "Let's go."

Bow smiled at her, then dropped his hand slowly, in time for Glimmer to teleport between them.

Scorpia nodded, ceasing her nervous little blasts of energy, Catra watched her friend from the Horde look her up and down, with a proud smile on her face.

"Making plans, saving the world," she sniffled, "I'm just…I'm so proud of you Wild Cat."

Don't speak too soon, Catra's gut coiled with shame. *This is far from over.*

Glimmer teleported between them.

“Sparkles….I know you don’t usually trust me, and that’s completely fair…I don’t trust me either but…” Catra readied her justification for going, but the princess held up a hand.

“Come on,” she waved her wrist dismissively. We’re going.”

Catra opened her mouth to argue, then stopped, giving Glimmer a trusting grin.. A blast of pink sparkling energy engulfed them all, a wind that whipped her cape and her hair, the sickening pounding of magic in her gut, her feet lifted off the floor in a terrible spiral of light and shimmering and….

“Oh stars,” Scorpia’s voice cracked, “are we…was that?”

“Yup! Well done!” Bow’s voice woke Catra from her stupor. She blinked, massaging her temples.

“No time for that now Shera, we got work to do. Buckle up buttercup,” Glimmer teased, giving Catra a good yank on her cape.

“Quit it Spar…”

The words died in Catra’s throat.

“What is this place?”

They stood in a large corridor, more grand than anything in Brightmoon, but darker. Colder, somewhere no one had been in a long time.

How did George and Lance ever find out about this place? Nevermind, there’s no time.

“Woah, look over here,” Glimmer pointed, Catra followed her. “I think…I think those are my parents.”

Catra looked up at the sprawling murial etched into the wall. Indeed a figure as regal and Angella stood, wings fully splayed out, her hands cupped around the Moonstone. Below her, a figure of King Micha, his mighty staff aloft.

“Is that, is that Shera?”

Scorpia asked, several lengths down the hall. Catra ran up to her, looking.

“It…it is…”

But it's not Adora, different hair…and her headpiece, Catra's fingers brushed her own crowned adornment encircling her ears, *more like mine but…different. How many Shera's have there been? And they all failed?*

Her heart hammered in her chest, blood running with ice.

"Come on," she forced confidence. "It's this way," without thinking, she knew where to go. Her soul-mark beating, the magic of Etheria itself seeming to guide her. Similar to the way she was able to read the First One's writing.

They walked silently, Catra going first, whip out and held tight, ready to snap, followed by Glimmer and Scorpia then Bow. Treading carefully through the shadowed corridors of the ancient chambers.

Just like a mission from the Horde, Catra reminded herself with each step, *eyes forward. Be alert. No time for looking around. Straight to the failsafe.*

It guided her, through some mystery she did not know.

There's no time to ask questions. I can ask Adora later, when all of this is done.

"In here," Catra turned left, facing two large arching doorways embossed with First Ones writing.

"Umm…W…what does it say?" Scorpia whispered, "not that I don't know how to read. I can read. I love reading. But just…I can't…I can't read…that," she gestured to the symbols on the door. Catra looked them over,

"It's instructions," she explained, reaching out and touching her hand to the smooth stone. The hairs on her arm stood on edge.

"Friend of the last Shera."

"I am a friend of Adora," Catra commanded.

The doors swung open, dank, misty air blowing forth.

That'll be the easiest part.

Catra's ears pricked up, waiting for any sound but their own footsteps.

"Where are Prime's clones?" Glimmer wondered as they walked through, "you think they'd be here by now."

“He might not know we’re even here yet,” Bow whispsered.

“Yeah,” Catra approached the center of the room, a large circular dias raised on a pedestal. “Let’s keep it that way.”

She stopped, a huge towering sheet of stone before them on the dias, etched with First Ones writing all over, impossibly tall, so enormous she couldn’t make out the top.

“This…this failsafe, is in there?” Scorpia asked. Catra could tell she was hanging back, from the way her voice echoed far off.

Yes, the magic of Shera seemed to answer for her. *Yes this is it.* Her blood stirred, her steps not nearly her own. The magic, it pulsed and pulled and begged her to go forward. Catra clenched her wrists, her breaths shaky.

For Adora.

For Etheria.

“If what my dad’s told me is correct,” Bow began, “the failsafe itself is a code, stored inside that crystal,” he pointed. “It needs a password.”

Catra nodded, she already knew the answer.

For Adora.

She held her breath, placing her hand against it.

"We're friends of Adora."

Instantly light burst from her connection to it, exploding in white light that ran up the length of the crystal, illuminating the First One's writing.

Adora? Can she come?

Secret hope stirred inside Catra, mixed with fear and the desperate, childish need for reassurance. Funny, how she could be Shera, powerful beyond measure and still that scared shaking little cadet hiding in her bunk.

Adora must have been terrified too.

She glanced down at her soul-mark which still echoed with its own light.

“Uhhh, Wild Cat?”

The crystals moved, shifting, splitting into three pieces, revealing their insides. She leapt out of the way, as white light at the base formed a triangle in the middle of the crystal pieces. The First One’s writing on the inside levitated away from the surface of the crystals walls.

“What does it say?”

Catra crouched at the steps of the dias now, trying to read the words through the garish bright.

“Someone…needs to go inside,” her voice cracked, “and accept the Fail Safe.”

What does that mean?

“It’ll be dangerous for you,” Adora’s words came to her clear as day as though the woman stood before her.

“It means,” Catra closed her eyes, trying to access her soulmate’s memories. So deep, so deep inside of her. Not of her, but a part of her nonetheless. “It means the failsafe must be bonded to a soul

and carried to the Heart of Etheria in their body in order to be deployed."

The light cracked, buzzing with lightning.

"A…are we sure that's safe?" Scorpia mumbled. Catra turned back to them, Glimmer's face drawn with severe concern, Bow shocked but unafraid and Scorpia's face wide on the verge of panic, her claws pinicing erratically, tail swiveling.

"I can't turn back now," Catra whispered, looking at her soul-mark, lifting it closer. "The Fail Safe is within our grasp."

The magic jolted again, making her tail stand on end, her ears perk forward.

We're close now, so close.

She looked around for Adora, through the illumination of the crystals for any sign of the previous Shera.

"Catra," Scorpia's voice called her back. "A…are you sure about this?"

Not really.

"I have to do this Scorpia."

She stepped up the stairs, towards the blinding magical light.

"You're not alone Wild Cat, we…were here, with you just, just be careful."

"Thanks, Scorp. Anything happens look after Sparkles and Arrow Boy for me okay?"

She turned before she could see the look on Scopia's face.

"Catra!" Glimmer shrieked, "Wai…"

The princesses voice was lost to the roar of magical energy as Catra stepped through, giving herself over to the power of Etheria. The magic seized on her in an instant, bursting through her hands and her feet, she flet herself lifting off the ground, hair and cape and her whip flying, levitating, pushed upward by magic, then stopped. She tried to open her eyes through the hazy white, but closed them again, it was too much. The magic set her blood aflame, Catra opened her mouth, letting out some sort of noise.

The sword in the woods.

Another image of another Shera.

Adora?!

A scream.

Someone was screaming. Was it her? Scorpia? Bow? Impossible to tell.

"Adora!"

Catra cried through the agony that filled her, the magic wreaking havoc inside of her. Her chest cynched for breath, heart beating so furiously it might stop. Catra opened her eyes, white magic blazing through her. A trail of something carving into her chest. She shrieked, worse than any magic Shadow Weaver possessed. She tried to curl in on herself, no use. More screams, something green, then pink flashed somewhere in the distance.

"Catra?"

"Adora?!"

A figure appeared and reappeared through the screen of white all around her, just beyond her reach. Catra lifted her hand, trying to

beckon it forward.

"You're so close Catra, just hang on. I'm here, I'm here with you. You're going to be okay."

"Adora!"

"That's it Catra, that's it, it'll be over soon. I'm right here. I'm right here."

"Adora! Adora P…p…please…s..stay! Stay with me!"

"Ca…"

The image faded, though she couldn't even lift her wrist to assure herself of the soul mark. Her limbs, they were too heavy, they were on fire. Her chest, on fire. Catra screamed, descending, slowly, slowly back to the ground, her mind racing. She crumbled, covering her head with her hands.

"Catra?!"

Arrow Boy.

She opened her eyes, trying to steady herself. His hand on her shoulder grounded her.

"Are you okay?"

She glanced down at the burning on her chest, then sucked a breath. There, just below the collar bone, a mark, hung like a hologram suspended over her chest.

The Fail-Safe.

It was heart-shaped, in the style of the First Ones. Glowing with its own pure light.

"I…I think so," she placed her hand above it. Watching as it shimmered against her touch.

"Okay," Bow spoke urgently, "That's great because we have a problem."

Catra pulled herself to her feet, still shaking, disoriented.

"What is it?"

“Aaaargghh!” Glimmer’s unmistakable wrath screamed through the chamber, followed by a blast of pink sparkling magic. Something gave a grunt, toppling over.

Clones, Prime knows we’re here.

Three more ran through the door, towards Scorpia, who clasped her claws together, red energy making them spasm and fall.

“Look out!”

Catra ducked out of the way just in time, Bow shot an arrow, pining another clone to the wall.

“We have to get out of here!” Glimmer hit another clone across the chest with her staff.

Catra nodded, slowly regaining composure. Another clone shoved past Scorpia, she cracked her whip, smiling satisfied as it jolted with magic, sending the clone flying backward.

“Come on!”

She sprinted down the dias, grabbing Scorpia’s arm, then Glimmer, heading towards the hall.

“Do you have the Fail-Safe?” Glimmer panted as they rounded the corner. Bow shot another volley of arrows towards the clones who advanced down the corridor, followed immediately by Scorpia’s magic.

“Yeah,” Catra grunted, slashing her whip, taking out the clone who managed to push through, “I got it!”

They ran over the bodies of the clones, back to the main hall. Taking out several more along the way.

“Good!” Glimmer swung in front of Scorpia and blocked another attack with her staff. “Ugh! Now you just have to use it!”

Catra sent her whip snaking through the air, coming down on a clone’s head, it fell forward, she shoved it, the Fail-Safe blinking as the clone fell off of her.

Yeah, using the Fail-Safe….that’s what I’m afraid of.

- - -

“We can’t split up!” Scorpia balked at the suggestion. Outside of the temple of Mystacor, with armies of clones surrounding them on all sides, Catra tried to quell her fear.

"We don't have a choice, Scorp. I need to get the fail-safe to the Heart. You have to help Sparkles and Arrow Boy here take down the rest of the clones, they'd be useless without you," she gestured, laughing at her own lame attempt at humor. The magic of the fail-safe pulsed against her chest, in time with her soul-mark. All around them green flashes of the clones descended.

We're running out of time Adora, Catra clenched her fists.

"But…but you can't go alone!"

"I won't be alone," Catra glanced at her soul-mark. Conjuring Adora's face in her mind. "I'll be okay, I need you to help the princesses okay?"

Scorpia held her gaze for a moment, Catra almost melted under its intensity. All of the love, trust and well-placed concern found therein. Her heart hammered in her chest, making her magic flutter. She tried to summon Shera, tried to project confiance. But everytime she did, the sound of another round of cannon fire made her magic spark and fade. She touched Scorpia's shoulder, whispering gently.

"I…I don't say this often okay so listen to me. I'm really, really proud of you Scorpia." She managed a tense smile, it was true, and she wished she could be in Shera form, giving this speech to Scorpia at some post-war party, Adora by her side. Instead the ground shuddered, leaves whipping around them, the clouds gray and storming.

A purple flash illuminated the sky, contrasting with the dark clouds.

"That's Entrapta's signal!" Bow pointed, "they need help, we have to go!"

Shit why can't we just have more time?!

Catra squeezed Sorpia's shoulder,

"You can hug me for as long as you want when this is all over okay?"

The large woman gasped with glee,

"Really?!"

"Yes, but please you have to go! Now!"

Scorpia pouted, then straightened, nodding.

“I’ll see you soon, Wild Cat.”

Glimmer’s touch on her arm made Catra’s tail lash, but she softened, gifting Glimmer with a rare genuine smile.

“Take care of her Sparkles, take care of yourself too.”

“Speak for yourself Horde Scum, I’ll kill you myself if I don’t see you after this.”

Catra did a mock bow, watching the three of them dash off into the tumult.

Looks like you're alone now.

No, I’m not alone.

Adora.

Adora promised she’d be there with me.

Catra took a deep breath, her fingers unconsciously brushing the mark on her wrist. She took off, letting instinct, magic, whatever it

was, guide her towards the Heart of Etheria.

- - -

It all came back to the Crystal Castle. Of course it did, back to the place where it all began. The sword, the magic, discovering Shera, that first transformation.

I might've guessed.

Catra thought bitterly, walking through the dark corridors, the walls peppered with the script of the First Ones.

"Come on Adora, I could really use a pep-talk right now," Catra tried transforming again. Tried to change, with every shutter from the battle above. Desperately trying to recall Adora. Her light, her face, those beautiful eyes. The ties that bound them together. Nothing. Each attempt was futile. A glimmer of magic, then nothing. Only the fail-safe, and her soul-mark.

The hall of the castle gleamed green, magic fizzing.

I must be close.

Catra picked up her pace, taking her sword from its sheath as she rounded another hall. The walls gleamed green again, sending her magic pricking to alert not unlike the hair on the back of her head.

“Ad…Adora?”

“Adora?!”

“Ador…”

Is that…?

Shera…or rather it looked like Shera, Adora’s Shera, just there at the end of the hallway. Catra stopped in her tracks, holding her breath, watching. The halls flashed light green, Adora walked towards her in her Shera form, smiling and radiant. Her strides confidant. Catra’s breath came in quick bursts, she held her wrists.

Adora?!

She came closer, the halls flashed again, still Adora coming ever nearer, but changing each time. Her Shera form got smaller, her trailing cape shorter, her headdress slightly less refined though it still retained two golden wings. Adora smiled through it all, filling Catra with hope even as dust from above fell between them. Catra held her breath, Adora’s form changed in and out, until she was close, so close, back to the glowing pure light form how she had first appeared, the Shera Catra knew best. The woman she loved. Adora reached out her hands, Catra shivered with anticipation, those delicate pale fingers ready to grace her face. She held

Adora’s hand, cupping it in her own, holding Adora’s hand to her cheek. She closed her eyes.

Warmth

Such unique and effervescent warmth.

Adora, Catra hummed, content, her tail languidly swishing back and forth. That light touch, so divine she thought her heart would shatter in bliss.

Ador….

“Catra!?!”

The image shattered, Adora’s form blipped and fizzled out in a green mess of little dots.

“W..who’s there?!”

Catra growled, pulled from her reverie. She willed to transform to Shera herself, but was only met with a pathetic spark of magic before it died in her palm.

“Adora?! Where are you!?” She glanced at her soul-mark. Untouched. Unglowing.

“How is that….it always shines when I’m around her….unless…”

Sticky tar gripped her stomach, she gulped, looking around the now dark hall.

“Catra!!!!”

“Scorpia?!”

“Sparkles?!”

No…I know that voice but…

Catra held her hands to her chest, folded over the fail-safe, as if she could do anything to protect it in her normal form. Still, she pressed onward, going towards the voice that cried for her. A faint light at the end of the long corridor, the script on the wall gleamed. Her magic pulsed.

I must be getting closer…

“Catra! Please!”

Catra entered a large high-vaulted room, dark green and white. There, in the center of it all: was him.

“So you are the Shera that never should have been,” Prime drawled.

…and I thought Hordak was scary.

Whatever Catra was expecting, this wasn’t it. Prime’s tall imposing figure stood like a monolith, his physic matching that of the other clones, but…larger, and with tendrils of hair coming out of his head. Regal almost, and wholly terrifying.

Adora…where are you? Please….

Prime took a step forward towards her, Catra’s tail stood on end, her ears pinned to her skull. She could hardly look at him as he danced around her, the way Shadow Weaver had so many times before. Sizing her up. Assessing her. Only to be told she was useless and lazy.

Adora give me strength please, she whispered to herself like a prayer, bringing herself to meet all four of Prime’s unsettling eyes.

“I must admit this is a surprise. In all my time as ruler of the cosmos, I never imagined Shera would return. Not after the last one. What was her name again?” He put a clawd finger to his chin for theatrics, “A…Addalor? Adama? Adora! Yes, the Shera who failed,” Prime hissed behind Catra’s back. His sour breath rank. She shivered, swallowing a lump in her throat.

“It was a pity really. She put up a good fight, even towards the end. Even when my virus had taken over her. She may have beaten me that time, but it was joy to watch her expire in the effort.”

“Shut up,” Catra snarled, rage blossoming past the terror in her chest. Prime smiled.

“Have I touched a nerve? You knew her didn’t you? Or rather, you should never have known her. That’s what happens with doomed soul mates I suppose,” he flicked his wrist casually dismissively. “It doesn't matter, you are no Shera. I watched the last vestige of life fade from her eyes long ago. You are a mistake, a defect and you will be disposed of as such.”

Catra pinned her eyes shut, sucking in a breath.

Breathe out when he hits you, just like Shadow Weaver. It’ll help with the blow. Transform damn it! Stupid fail-safe!

“Oh but I almost forgot,” he paused before her, raising one large claw. “There is someone here to see you.”

“Catra!!!” The voice shrieked again. Catra whirled around, ears trying to discern who it was.

“You better unhand her!” The rage within her quickly rose, somewhere deep inside her, the magic did too, making her bold, but not enough to transform.

“If you dare touch Glimmer or Scorpia I swear I’ll…”

Prime’s laugh drowned out her words, he shook his head.

“I will have to find this Scorpia, this…Glimmer, whoever you care for. But that is not who has come to see you,” he spoke slowly, looking down on Catra with amusement.

“She believed in you, despite her animosity. She believed you’d come for her.”

Catra shuddered, taking a deep breath, following Prime’s gaze down the far end of the vast room. There, from the shadows stepped a figure.

L…Lonnie?!

Her former squad mate grinned, dressed in white ribes emblazoned with the Horde's insignia. Her hazel eyes gone, replaced with two glowing green orbs. She watched, stepping back involuntarily as Lonnie…this version of her, came forward an eerie grin, too wide, plastered to her face as if sown on by a clone.

"I have no need to stay and watch your games Catra," Prime strode past her. "I will see you at the end of this. You have already lost."

He gave her a nodd, then walked past her, past Lonnie and a beam of green light engulfed him.

Catra's magic flared, she shivered with a sudden chill at his cavalier leave.

That was it…? He just…

"What the…."

Catra jumped back at the last second as Lonnie pounced on her, whipping out one of the electric batons from the horde, only this one, a staff, and it glowed cracked with green lightening.

“Lonnie!”

Catra dodged again, barely, half tumbling, half vaulting away as her former squad-mate attacked again.

“Lonnie! Listen to me….!”

The fellow cadet made a jab at her, swinging the staff, her glowing green eyes narrowing.

“You abandoned us in the Whispering Woods!”

Catra let out a squeal, heat from the electricity grazing her side. She rolled but Lonnie was fast, leaping on her in an instant. Catra clamped her hands around the staff and pinned her to the ground, its light illuminating their faces, Lonnie’s malicious grin inches from her.

“Lonnie!” Catra grunted, trying to right herself, but whatever had been to her made Lonnie impossibly strong. “I know you..urgh,,,hate me…you're not my best friend either…” Catra grunted trying to twist away. “But I’m getting you out of here!” She slid out from under the hold, sliding behind Lonnie, sword out. The staff came crashing down, colliding with her blade. Catra sprang backward, then made to block the whirling staff again. Lonnie clenched her teeth,

“You think you’re the only one who wanted to be a Force Captain?!”

Catra kicked out, hitting Lonnie in the back of the knee. The girl went down, momentarily.

“Lonnie…j…just stick this out and you can be!”

Catra cried, avoiding another attack,

“Just stop this and you can be Force Captain…well, the Horde’s all but destroyed now,” she narrowly avoided another swipe. “....but Lonnnie, just hang on and I’ll make you Captain of the Brightmoon guard okay? When this is all over! You deserve it!”

Lonnie’s fist slammed into Catra’s cheek, vision blurred, she stumbled swinging blindly with her sword.

“Come on! What can’t I transform, why can’t I…aargh!”

Lonnie grabbed her from behind, wrenching her arms behind her back in a single move.

“You think you got hurt in the Horde? We were all kids in here,” she hissed, Catra squirmed. “We were all hurting. You weren’t the

only one Shadow Weaver took her anger out on."

She's right.

"Aaargh!!" Catra tried to reach around, tried to bite at her, snarling and spitting, forsaking any dignity. If Shera wasn't going to help her, her instincts would.

"I pushed myself, I tried, I showed up to every drill on time, completed every simulation, why do you get to be the special one?"

Lonnie's voice quivered with rage, no longer a monotone drone of Prime. "I fought! I was loyal! I patched Kyle up in the woods when the skiff crashed! I learned how to communicate with Rogelio and I got beat for it!"

"Lonnie!" Catra tried to thrash but her squad-mate held fast.

Maybe I always underestimated her.

"You just stumble upon a sword and you get to be a hero! Get to play the righteous savior?!" Lonnie twisted her arms further, yanking back, her shoulders arching.

"Aaaarrchhhh!"

“You’ll never win. Not as Shera, not with Adora as your soul-mate. You’re not soul-mates if one of you is rotting in the ground.”

Catra arched backward, grabbing Lonnie and swinging her down, over her head. The girl tumbled, rolled, slammed into one of the columns. Something sparked.

Behind her neck….what is that….?

“Hahaa,” Lonnie laughed, making Catra’s blood freeze in her veins.

“Lonnie, we can get out of here. Together okay?! I know this isn’t you…isn’t all you…the Lonnie I knew would never let a dictator tell her what to do! You’re smarter than that! You always have been!”

Her eyes slipped back to green again.

“Hahahaha,” her laugh rose to a fever pitch. Catra glanced around, back towards the dark hall. Her magic sparked rising in her chest.

“You betrayed me, betrayed our squad, your friends, betrayed the Horde…and soon you’ll betray yourself, and your Adora. You’ll never see her again…never feel her.”

I could leave her here, get to the Heart.

I don't owe her anything.

" Lonnie, you have to fight it!"

"Oh Catra," Lonnie stood, folding her arms over her chest.

"No one will have to fight anymore. Once Prime takes over Etheria, there will be peace throughout the galaxy. No wars or hordes, no missions, no casualties. All will be at peace."

"This isn't you!"

Even if I leave her, she'll come after me. Lonnie's never been anything but a pain in my ass…she'll chase me down, or go after the others. She's thorough. Efficient. Always had been. Since we were kids. Even beat up and exhausted, she persisted.

"I don't want to leave you! And for once I don't want to fight you either!"

“Hahahah oh Catra, fighting is all you know how to do,” she lunged, diving, Catrra swung to the side, dodged one fist, then another. Catra winced as Lonnie’s fist hit her side, then stumbled but managed to avoid another blow. Lonnie spun,

…it’s a chip, Catra glanced at the sparking little chip in the back of her neck. Catra swung the sword again, blunt-side towards Lonnie. She grunted, feeling a sharp pain in her back as Lonnie struck her with the staff. Catra growled, twisting herself around and jumped up,landing on the girl’s shoulders.

“There you are,” Catra peered at the chip, brandishing the sword trying to hold it delicately evans Lonnie tried to grab for her.

“Just hold still! I’m trying to help you!” Lonnie thrashed madly, backing them both up into one of the columns. Catra hissed in pain, her back slamming into the hard surface. She tried to channel her magic, holding the sword.

Come on magic Etherian fail-safe or whatever, help me…I need this to be s..smaller…something enough to take out the chip something….

“Argh! Stop!”

Lonnie howled with fury trying to take her down. Catra’s palms spun with magic, light enveloping the sword. It shrunk in her hands, down to a tiny little tweezer.

“Lonnie, will you stop trying to kill me for five seconds?!”

Catra gripped the back of the girl’s head with one hand, trying to balance as she flung herself madly about. The other hand she used the tweezers to pry at the metal.

“Aaaaargh!” Catra’s body seized with pain, the bolts of green electricity going through her. Flooding through her veins, seeping into her, through her. The fail-safe on her chest seemed to phase in and out, it’s light quickening.

Forget this! Sorry not sorry Lonnie,

She reached for the chip with her claws and pulled, the wires resisted, then snapped. Sparks flew and Catra leapt off as Lonnie collapsed.

Her vision faded in and out, lying on the cold ground.

Adora…please…where are you? I…I can’t do all of this on my own.

Catra blinked, slowly, then tried to concentrate. Lonnie squirmed on the ground. Groaning. Catra pulled herself to her feet, her side and back, her face, all her body screeching with agony.

“Lonnie?”

Catra whispered low, rolling the girl over. Anxiously running her hands over Lonnie’s robes, loosening the fabric around her neck.

Lonnie spluttered, coughed, her chest wracked with heavy breathing.

Damn you Lonnie! Thank the stars.

“Hey, easy there, easy, Lonnie, easy!”

She helped Lonnie sit up, reaching for the small communication device near her ear.

“Sparkles, come in Sparkles.”

It buzzed,

“Catra thank the stars are you okay?!! I…I mean…what do you want, Horde Scum?”

“I found someone down here, under the Crystal Caste. I need you to teleport down here and get her. Get her somewhere safe. Can you do that?”

“I…is she a princess?”

“We don’t have time for that Sparkles! Can you get her?”

“Fine, give me a minute.”

The static fazed out.

“C…Catra,” Lonnie slowly coughed, Catra patted her back, firm but gentle.

“Lonnie, I knew you wouldn’t die on me!”

Lonnie, come on. Don’t you dare die on me.”

Her former squad-mate grimaced, opening her eyes once more, mouth contorting into a self-satisfied grin, even through thin breaths.

“Hmph…w..wouldn’t give you the..s…satisfaction.”

They shared a small smile.

“ I…I have so many questions for you when you’re ready…”

“Yeah, me too.”

“W…was Prime right? About what he said?”

Catra suddenly felt small next to her former squad-mate. Like she wasn’t sure if she wanted to know the answer.

“About you believing in me…?”

Lonnie stared at her, then opened her mouth to answer. Sparkles pink and purple magic came into view.

“Catra! Is this her?”

Catra looked between them, nodding.

“Yes, this is Lonnie, Prime…he…he chipped her but I managed to get it out. It’s in the back of their neck you have to dislodge it.”

Glimmer nodded, then looked to Lonnie, helping her stand.

“Come on, we have to get back, quick.”

“I’ll see you soon Catra. Just get to the Heart, destroy it, get out okay? Scorpia misses you already.”

“S…Scorpia is with you?!” Lonnie’s eyes blared wide.

“I’ll explain later, okay? Sparkles get out of here, quick before he comes back.”

Glimmer’s face looked horrified, even as she scooped Lonnie up.

“Prime?! You met him?!”

“Not now Sparkles go!”

Magic spun around the princess, she and Lonnie slowly fading from view.

"Bye Catra," she managed.

"See you soon, Glimmer."

The girls shared a smile, then both of them disappeared, and Catra was left, Shera-less, without her soulmate, facing down the last dark ancient hall that led to the Heart of Etheria.

Adora….we….we can do this……..can't we?

She limped down the hall,one hand to her side,

…at least the hard part is over.

- - -

Just keep going, that's it…I can do this…uhhhh, I can't be far now…right Adora? Where is she?

Catra tried to trudge forward, each step agony. She held the wound on her side gingerly, shuddering each time her claws grazed the burn. Whatever Lonnie stabbed her with…it was no ordinary stun button. Catra listed to the side, catching herself on the wall, trying to catch her breath. She peered down at the fail-safe, blinking slowly.

Why are my eyes so heavy?

"Uuurgh," she pulled herself onward, closer towards the pulsing yellow and green lights ahead. She gleaned at her soul-mark, holding her breath.

Where's Adora? She should be here…I've never been closer to the heart of Etheria…the magic should be stronger then ever.

Catra lumbered onward, holding the fail-safe to her chest, as if it wasn't already burned into her. She held her breath, bracing herself before the glowing white energy before her, ever-closer.

This is it.

She tried to transform herself, tried desperately, but her magic only flickered.

Adora, help me.

I'm ready.

She stepped forward, into the Heart of Etheria and crumbled to the ground.

- - -

The Whispering Woods.

Trees, full and thriving, their multi-colored crowns spreading out as far as the eye could see.

Lights drifted around her, through the whole of the woods. Magical, undisturbed.

Did…did we do it? Was that it?

Sparkles might be right about this dumpy planet after all. Catra grinned, feeling the power of the planet fill her.

"Catra!"

She turned, startling,

"Adora!"

The former Shera stood before her, divine as ever, shimmering.

Catra couldn't help herself, she rushed forward, ready to fling herself into Adora's arms, though she knew it was pointless.

Warmth, light and smelling of the sun.

Is…this is happening, Catra realized when her body hit Adora's solid form. Her eyes welled with tears, burying herself in the sensation.

"A…Adora," she whispered into the woman's chest. Curling her arms around her tightly. Unable to let go.

"Catra," Adora breathed, one large hand stroking through her hair. "We don't have much time."

Catra pulled herself from the embrace, face red.

"Wh…what?"

"This is an illusion, Prime, he's controlling it all. You're in the Heart of Etheria but you need to transform into Shera.

Catra shook her head, tightening her grip on Adora. Perfect, solid, stable Adora who was holding her tight. Finally at last.

“I don’t want to,” she whispered quietly. “I don’t want to leave you.”

Adora’s fingers minstreled through her hair.

“I know.”

Adora’s lips brushed the top of her head, Catra could feel the soul-mark on her wrist warm and glowing.

“Shera….”

Catra and Adora whipped around, searching, the Whispering Woods no longer vibrant and alive. Instead the scenery shivered, light green light of Prime’s tech rippling through. His voice echoed all around.

“This is the future you wished for isn’t it Catra? You and your Adora, the Shera who never was. The one who failed.”

Adora’s form sparked and nearly faded.

“Adora! Don’t you touch her!”

Catra reached for her sword, only to fumble with her belt.

"What a beautiful future…but there will be no happiness, no soul-mates reunited. I disposed of Adora and I will dispose of you!"

The world faded to black.

"Adora!!!!"

Catra screamed, falling backwards into nothingness and Adora's body crumbled into green light.

- - -

Catra strained against the burning agony, whatever tech Prime had activated, or the power of the magic itself bound her tight, crushing her.

Shadow Weaver's magic.

Hordak's punishments.

They were right…I can't do this….I'm no Shera.

"N….no! N…no…no…no!"

“Catra!”

A light somewhere distant…and…

“A…Adora?”

It can’t be true….?

“Catra!!!”

Adora reached out through the darkness, straining for her.

“Catra! You can do this! I believe in you!”

Tears rolled down her eyes, she tried to breath through her bonds, reaching for Adora.

“Catra! I….I love you!”

Her heart leapt, Catra burst through Prime’s hold, her hand locked with Adora’s, physical and solid, their fingers locking together.

Adora pulled her up, through the dark and Catra quickly pressed her lips to Adora's, her short cape billowing behind her. They kissed at once, light exploding from them, magic pouring out. Catra's eyes slipped shut, even as the fail-safe activated her only thoughts of Adora. Her sweet taste, her touch, her smell.

The world was all color and light and magic, all Adora. The two of them, the Shera of Old and the Shera of the Age of Magic Reborn.

- - -

"Are you sure this is okay?" Catra asked, "I'm sure we could ask Entrapta to…."

"Using a combination of Etheria's newly reborn magic and the First One's tech, Adora should be basically more or less alive. Not completely, not exactly, but her spirit is intact and her physicality tied to Etheria's magic so as long as that remains stable she should be fine! If this is replicable…that could change the meaning of life and death as we know it!" Entrapta squealed,

"Ooohh can we do more tests?!"

"No," Adora grinned from ear to ear, she reached out taking Catra's hand experimentally. No matter how many times she did it, Catra would never get used to the feeling. That rush of magical energy between them, Adora's unique warmth. "This is perfect, this is all I need."

Catra nodded, determined not to cry. Not in front of Sparkles or Arrow Boy or Entrapta.

She stepped closer to Adora, pressing their foreheads together. Even admit the rush of rebuilding, reconfiguring the Fright Zone, hunting down the remaining clones….Catra always felt at peace with Adora, their hearts beating in time.

Prime was defeated, completely obliterated by the power of both her's and Adora's Shera forms. The magic returned to Etheria.

"What do we do now?" Adora whispered, kissing her forehead with soft lips. Catra purred.

"Whatever we want."

Adora smirked, her hand lifting up and holding Catra's face, she looked into her eyes, reflecting in the golden huen sky. Catra leaned into her touch.

"I already have what I want."

"You're so corny, we're going to have to teach you better lines."

Adora laughed,

“Whatever you say, Shera.”

Catra’s chest exploded with joy, she rolled her eyes and kissed Adora once more.

This was always how it was always supposed to be.

End Notes

I am so excited to be able to write my Secret Solstice fic for Hopelessgemini! I really hope they enjoy it. I am a huge fan of their work both Glimbow and Catradora fic's and you should totally check them out! They gave me a lot of things to work with in terms of likes and dislikes and things they would like to see in the fic. After mulling things over and tossing several other ideas I decided on this basic premise: "What if Catra and Adora were soulmates...but some weird portal stuff happened so that they never actually met and...what if Catra became Shera?" With those ideas in mind I went for it, and hope you enjoy!

Happy Solstice and Happy Holidays!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!